

Moving Viewers

American Film and the Spectator's Experience

CARL PLANTINGA

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For my parents

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2. Movies and Emotions

Conceive yourself, if possible, suddenly stripped of all the emotions with which your world now inspires you, and try to imagine it as it *exists*, purely by itself, without your favorable or unfavorable, hopeful or apprehensive comment. It will be almost impossible for you to realize such a condition of negativity and deadness. No one portion of the universe would then have importance beyond another; and the whole collection of its things and series of its events would be without significance, character, expression, or perspective. Whatever of value, interest, or meaning our respective worlds may appear imbued with are thus pure gifts of the spectator's mind And as the excited interest which these passions put into the world is our gift to the world, just so are the passions themselves gifts.

WILLIAM JAMES¹

Movies have seemed to many observers to be excellent metaphors for, or approximations of, human consciousness. If consciousness is to some extent self-directed through the patterns of salience we impose on the world around us, then, as Oliver Sacks writes, a movie,

with its taut stream of thematically connected images, its visual narrative integrated by the viewpoint and values of its director, is not at all a bad metaphor for the stream of consciousness itself. And the technical and conceptual devices of cinema—zooming, fading, dissolving, omission, allusion, association and juxtaposition of all sorts—rather closely mimic (and perhaps are designed to mimic) the streamings and veerings of consciousness.²

Sacks's insight derives in part from the work of other scholars whose writing straddles the boundaries of philosophy and psychology. The early film theorist Hugo Munsterberg had similar ideas,³ as did his colleague at Harvard, William James. James wondered if consciousness, although it seems continuous, is actually discontinuous and subject to the same sorts of illusions as a zoetrope. Henry Bergson wrote that the "mechanism of our ordinary knowledge is of a cinematographic kind."⁴ Given that the cinema, in some way, mimics human consciousness, then we can understand why it makes sense to understand a film as a "way of seeing." Similarly, V.F. Perkins describes film as "the projection of a mental universe—a mind recorder."⁵ For our purposes, however, "seeing" may be far too restricted,

and “mental universe” may suggest something cold or abstract; a film is not only a way of seeing, but also a way of hearing, feeling, thinking, and responding. It presents not just a mental universe (of perception and cognition), but a holistic experience connected to the emotions, affects, and the body. It offers a particular experience of what it displays, of the fictional world presented. This way of experiencing mimics the phenomenological contours of conscious experience generally, and thus is complex and multifaceted.

The attractions of such “ways of experiencing” are many and diverse, but chief among them is the ability of many films to elicit emotion in the spectator, to provide suspense, surprise, fear, screams, anxiety, tears, relief, and calm in a temporal order that is vivid and ultimately pleasurable. If films approximate conscious experience like no other medium, they do so also in their ability to elicit emotional responses to that experience. Those emotions, as they occur inside and outside the movie theater, are the subject of this chapter. Before writing about emotion, however, I first posit some basic principles of human psychology that lie at the heart of my theory. I then discuss the psychology of emotion generally, and go on to show how film-elicited emotions relate to general human emotion.

AUTOMATICITY AND THE PSYCHOLOGICAL UNCONSCIOUS

I call my theory of the elicitation of emotion in film a *cognitive-perceptual* theory. This I distinguish from what might be called (somewhat archly) “cognitive fundamentalism,” which could be said to overemphasize the role of consciousness and deliberate cognition in the generation of emotional and affective response. Some critics of cognitive theories have assumed that all cognitive theorists insist on purely conscious evaluations in the genesis of human emotion. That is, the cognitive theorist might be thought to claim, for example, that the experience of fear requires that the fearing subject consciously subsume the feared object under the category “seriously threatening” or “dangerous” to the subject’s life or well-being, and that such conscious deliberation must *precede* having the emotion of fear. On the contrary, much of what leads a person to have an emotion must occur at the level of what I call, after Gerard O’Brien and Jon Jureidini, the “cognitive unconscious.” The feeling of fear is felt consciously, of course. But the processes leading up to that feeling may or may not occur consciously. Most cognitive theorists reserve an important place for the unconscious mind and unconscious mental processes—for the

cognitive unconscious. As O'Brien and Jureidini write, it "is the *sine qua non* of contemporary cognitive science that human cognition [requires] unconscious operations."⁶ It is also true, I would argue, that human emotion requires unconscious operations.

O'Brien and Jureidini claim that a good deal of experimental work demonstrates the existence of unconscious information processing. Experiments with dichotic listening, in which subjects are simultaneously presented with two channels of auditory information, show that when asked to attend to information in one ear, the subjects cannot consciously remember the information presented in the other ear. Yet although the information given through the unattended channel is not remembered consciously, subsequent behavior of the subjects suggests that the information has somehow been processed. Other research in subliminal perception shows that many kinds of stimuli presented below the threshold of consciousness can influence a subject's subsequent behavior.⁷ These studies both suggest that perceptual stimuli are processed unconsciously, at least in part. Additional evidence for this psychological unconscious comes from studies in automaticity, cognitive neuropsychology, and hypnosis.⁸

The idea of the unconscious mind predates Sigmund Freud and psychoanalysis. In the nineteenth century, in his *Treatise on Physiological Optics*, Hermann von Helmholtz argued for the existence of unconscious inferences:

The psychic activities that lead us to infer that there in front of us at a certain place there is a certain object of a certain character, are generally not conscious activities, but unconscious ones. In their result they are the equivalent to *conclusion*, to the extent that the observed action on our senses enables us to form an idea as to the possible cause of this action. . . . But what seems to differentiate them from a conclusion, in the ordinary sense of that word, is that a conclusion is an act of conscious thought. . . . Still it may be permissible to speak of the psychic acts of ordinary perception as *unconscious conclusions*.⁹

The cognitive unconscious is not limited to cognition, however. Researchers are currently interested in discovering more about unconscious perception, unconscious affect, and unconscious conation (pleasure and desire).¹⁰

There is much about the unconscious mind that is poorly understood, but it makes sense to appeal to a contemporary view of the psychological unconscious over Freudian models. Berkeley psychologist John F. Kihlstrom, long a proponent of what he calls the "rediscovery" of the unconscious, writes that there exists scant evidence for Freud's view that

the unconscious "is the repository of primitive, infantile, irrational, sexual and aggressive impulses, repressed in a defensive maneuver to avoid conflict and anxiety."¹¹ The presence of an unconscious mind, I would argue, does not require an acceptance of Freud's particular schematization of it, or indeed any account rooted in some variation of psychoanalysis. The psychological unconscious is generally directed toward personal well-being (or adaptation, if you will), and is driven by motives beyond Freud's libido and aggression, such as desires for achievement, power, affiliation, and intimacy. The psychological unconscious, moreover, is modular and fragmented, sometimes consisting of the activity of narrowly focused processing modules or components; in this way, also, it differs from Freud's unitary unconscious, which typically functions at an executive level to control psychological activity.

Much of our behavior and many of our responses to our environment are beyond conscious control. Most of the time, we do not consciously decide to breathe, yet we do so. A sudden loud noise can shake us to the core without, of course, any conscious deliberation. Charles Darwin famously recounted his experience by the reptile cages at the zoo:

I put my face close to the thick glass-plate in front of a puff-adder in the Zoological Gardens, with the firm determination of not starting back if the snake struck at me; but, as soon as the blow was struck, my resolution went for nothing, and I jumped a yard or two backwards with astonishing rapidity. My will and reason were powerless against the imagination of a danger which had never been experienced.¹²

Our ability to exercise conscious, intentional control over our behavior and responses is limited. Much of our behavior and many responses occur as a result of unconscious mental processes. In other words, they are automatic and not mediated by deliberate consideration.

Automaticity has been the subject of much interest in recent psychological research, with serious implications for any theory of spectator response to films. I will explore particular automatic responses in film spectatorship more fully in Chapter 4, but here I will simply introduce the concept as central to the cognitive-perceptual theory of response. Automaticity refers to the idea that certain patterns of human response in relation to perceived stimuli occur without conscious deliberation. They are not carefully considered but rather immediate, as though they were programmed into us. Such patterns, whether innate, established through experience, or the result of cognitive "framing," enable humans to respond to their environment quickly and efficiently. Automaticity manifests itself in three major forms: (1) the automatic effect of perception on tendencies

toward action, (2) the automatic pursuit of goals, and (3) the continued automatic evaluation of one's experience.¹³

For example, most responses to the environment are determined not solely by the information available in the environment, but by how that information relates to a person's goals. If my goal is to escape harm from a threatening beast, I likely won't stop to admire a magnificent landscape I happen to pass on my escape route. My escape-related behavior and mental processing become automatic in relation to my goal of survival. My attention is directed to the salient details of the environment to accomplish that goal, and my body readies itself for the appropriate physical responses required for the situation. The goal of survival, once established, automatically structures my perception until I perceive the danger to abate. Automaticity also functions in film viewing in relation to goals. One might say that if film spectators become intensely interested in a narrative outcome, they develop the goal of discovering that outcome. This goal becomes automatic, and in part governs their response to the unfolding narrative until the goal is achieved. I respond with anticipation, curiosity, and suspense, because the narration has successfully established my overarching concern to find out what happens.

(On a side note, it must be noted that conscious deliberation may over time become automatic, replacing what were once conscious, deliberate mental activities with automatic responses and behaviors.¹⁴ The film viewer may thus become primed to respond in a particular fashion to types of characters or situations, either from conventions established within particular films or broader generic conventions of response-elicitation.)

To a remarkable degree, automatic responses outweigh conscious deliberation. Were we to have to consciously think about our every movement, action, and reaction, our conscious minds would be cluttered and we would be unable to live in the world. Automaticity allows us to attend to one thing at a time, while our unconscious minds perform a thousand tasks beneath the surface of consciousness.

"Conscious inessentialism" is the view that consciousness matters little in our moment-to-moment responses and judgments. Various considerations, however, make it difficult to accept conscious inessentialism. When we draw our conscious attention to our environment, we can exercise an element of control over our decisions and behavior. We can consciously form habits of mind and behavior that alter our automatic responses. We are not wholly free, but neither are we merely automatons. That we exercise some degree of self-conscious, active control is an assumption that we cannot dispense with, for on this belief in self-determination, even in

partial self-determination, rests the entire edifice of morality and justice, not to mention our sense of a self with a will, intentions, responsibility, accountability, and the ability to plan for a better future. So although I assign an important role to the cognitive unconscious and automatic responses in the generation of emotion, I also reserve a place for conscious judgment and deliberation in emotional life.

If our goal is to discover the means by which the unconscious mind responds to cinematic representation, we need not turn to psychoanalysis. Although it is as yet insufficiently developed in film and media studies, a cognitive-perceptual approach is not only more plausible, it also fits with contemporary research programs in psychology, cognitive science, and many related disciplines.

WHAT IS EMOTION?

With this basic understanding of the cognitive unconscious and the nature of automaticity, we can now turn to the emotions. I begin my account of emotion with a hypothetical example. For ease of reference, I will call this story "Jack, Jane, and the Bear." A man, Jack, is hiking in the mountains. He has been warned of grizzly bears in the area and is primed for danger. As he rounds a bend, he sees movement and the flash of a furry brown animal in the meadow a hundred yards in front of him. Jack's reaction is automatic and nearly involuntary; he becomes motionless, and his attention is fully drawn to the moving object. He places his arms at his sides, elbows bent, at the ready; he positions his feet so that, if necessary, he can quickly turn and flee or climb a tree; he thrusts his head slightly forward to get a better look. He slows his breathing so that he might hear every sound. His entire body, it seems, is directed toward identifying this potentially threatening entity and preparing for possible action. Then he recognizes that the animal is a large, brownish bear, foraging among the wild blueberry bushes. The bear senses Jack's presence, rears up on its hind legs, and spots Jack.

At this point, Jack perceives that the bear poses an immediate danger to his safety. His respiration quickens, his heart pounds, his stomach muscles tighten, and his mind races as he calculates the best plan of action. His eyes open wide and his eyebrows arch upward; his mouth opens. He is experiencing the emotion of fear. The bear begins to charge forward, toward Jack. Jack lets out an involuntary yell, his arms extended outward, and begins to back away slowly. The bear, however, for whatever reason, breaks off its charge, turns, and ambles away, moving out of sight. Jack's

fear slowly subsides as he realizes that he is no longer in imminent danger. Jack is at first relieved, then elated that he has escaped injury.

In this book, I define an emotion as an intentional mental state, or what I call a “concern-based construal,” that is often accompanied by various sorts of feelings, physiological arousal, and action tendencies. Emotions are disturbances, departures from the normal state of relative composure. Jack’s fear is complex, involving (1) a primal concern for survival, (2) a perception or construal that survival is threatened, (3) physiological and autonomic nervous system (ANS) changes, (4) the subjective experience of strong feelings, (5) a mental and physical state of excitement or perturbation, (6) a specific form of behavior or action readiness (flight, defense), and (7) other outward manifestations in behavior (body language, facial expressions).

Most of these elements have been thought at one time or another to be the essence of an emotion.¹⁵ Philosopher Robert C. Roberts, whose work has been influential in the development of my theory, rejects the tendency of some theorists to seek exceptionless generalizations in their accounts of emotion. Such a compulsion, he writes, “often leads to a procrustean and reductivist denial of facts and a conceptual artificiality that serve obfuscation as much as understanding.”¹⁶ Ronald de Sousa, another prominent philosopher of the emotions, takes a similar position.¹⁷ Yet while I would like to avoid talk of necessary and sufficient conditions in favor of a “family resemblance” account of human emotion, it is undoubtedly true that my account finds some elements of emotion to be central, or closer to necessary and sufficient conditions than others.¹⁸ Most importantly in this regard, I will be considering an emotion to be a kind of intentional relationship between a person and the world. At the core, an emotion is a mental state that is accompanied by physiological arousal.

A COGNITIVE-PERCEPTUAL APPROACH

Why a mental state? A cognitive-perceptual approach to emotions claims that kinds of emotions are distinguished in part according to kinds of individual appraisals or construals of a situation.¹⁹ To return to “The Bear,” Jack was frightened by the bear because he perceived that the bear threatened his survival. That is, he appraised or construed the bear as dangerous. Suppose that along with Jack on that day is another hiker, Jane. Jane is packing a small-caliber pistol in a side holster. She confidently (and wrongly) assumes that this diminutive weapon will protect her from any large and hairy beast. Jane also sees the bear, but Jane’s construal of the

situation will be different than Jack's. Jane is enthralled at the sight of this magnificent furry creature and believes that her trusty gun will protect her if it attacks. She feels only a twinge of fear, a fear that is submerged underneath the confidence her skill with the pistol gives her. As the bear charges, Jane holds the pistol in front of her, ready to fire if necessary. Since her small-caliber pistol is likely only to anger the bear if fired, Jane is in as much danger as Jack, if not more. Clearly, what distinguishes Jack's and Jane's emotional responses is their differing construals of the situation, not merely the "objective" situation itself. The kind of emotion experienced, then, depends not on the nature of the situation but on the appraisal of the perceiver.

Neither can emotions be defined by particular physiological or ANS responses. In the well-known Schachter and Singer experiment, persons injected with drugs to simulate the physiological characteristics that accompany emotions interpreted their own emotional states largely according to cues provided by researchers. Though undergoing strong physiological changes (such as increased respiratory and pulse rates), they did not report themselves as experiencing a particular emotion until they were provided a context of euphoria or anger, or in other words, until they were supplied with the appropriate "cognitions."²⁰

Again, this is evidence for the importance of construals or appraisals in emotional experience, as well as for the intentional nature of emotions. Emotions are intentional not in the sense of being deliberative and considered but in their "aboutness." They express a relationship between a person and the world. Thus fear, sadness, anger, jealousy, shame, and guilt are words we use to describe relationships between persons, on the one hand, and an object (person, situation, environment) on the other, in relation to the person's concerns.

Neither situation nor physiological response are sufficient to determine emotion; in many cases, the individual's construal of the situation determines the kind of emotion that is experienced.²¹ Lest this theory be considered too individualistic, however, it should be noted that individual construals are not always subject to the whims of an individual. Emotional experience is heavily influenced by cultural context and social convention, so we must not neglect the sense in which emotions, though experienced by individuals, are often shared and in part influenced by cultural and historical conditions.

In this book, as I said, I consider emotions to be mental states that are often accompanied by subjective feelings, physiological arousal, and action tendencies. Roberts provides a good model for such mental states. He calls

emotions *concern-based construals*. Two things need to be said immediately about emotions as “concern-based construals.” First, the construals of an emotion are not necessarily conscious states or carefully considered, reflective appraisals. As Roberts writes, “Construals have an immediacy reminiscent of sense perception. They are impressions, ways things appear to the subject; they are experiences and not just judgments or thoughts or beliefs.”²² A concern-based construal is like a perception in the extended sense of the word. It is the experiencing of a situation in its import; it may be felt as much as thought, it may be pre-reflective as much as reflective, and it may be, but is not necessarily, automatic. Although an emotion can be described in terms of a deliberative and conscious appraisal, it often results from what are, at least initially, unconscious and automatic processes.

Whether such a construal can properly be called “cognitive” in every instance depends on one’s definition of the term. Theorists such as Martha Nussbaum, Robert Solomon, and Richard Lazarus claim that emotions are judgments. If judgments are construed as deliberative and conscious, my view would not qualify as a cognitive theory. Taking a broader perspective, however, cognition is also associated with automaticity and the cognitive unconscious, and my view would qualify. The cognitive unconscious must play a central role in emotional response. The particular disposition of an emotion depends on a partly unconscious conceptual system that automatically structures a person’s experience and directs his or her behavior. Events are perceived to be more or less significant to the welfare of the self, and emotions are experienced depending on the automatic assessment of events and responses. Unlike Freud’s unconscious, the cognitive unconscious is available to consciousness through introspection (under strict conditions) and can be inferred in others via the observation of emotional behavior. Thus, an emotion may not be caused by conscious deliberation (a conscious construal), yet may nonetheless be justifiably described *ex post facto* as an intentional, cognitive state, because it can only be characterized accurately as a perceived relationship between persons and their environment in relation to their concerns.

Emotions may result not from conscious appraisals but from habits of mind, innate responses (the way that pigeons respond to shadows in the shape of a hawk, for example), or what might be called “affect programs.”²³ These are judgments, I suppose, in a loose sense. Emotions can also result from the associations of memory, when objects or events remind us of an emotion-laden past. Emotions might be modular, emanating despite conscious attempts to think oneself out of having that particular emotion.

Remember Charles Darwin's response to the adder recounted above. All of these factors—associations, habits of mind, and memory traces—may figure prominently into the experience and intensity of emotion. Whatever the causal genesis of emotions, be it conscious appraisals or processes that occur in the cognitive unconscious, emotions are intentional states expressive of a relationship between a person and the environment; they therefore have objects, that is, they are directed at something or someone, whether real or imagined.

So far I have discussed the nature of construals. What about concerns? Construals are "concern based," that is, as Roberts claims, they are "imbued, flavored, colored, drenched, suffused, laden, informed, or permeated with concern."²⁴ I have an emotion because I construe that a situation relates significantly to one or more of my concerns. Jack experiences fear in part because he is concerned with his safety; if he lacked this concern, then he would not have been fearful. I grieve at the loss of a loved one; I would not grieve had I not cared for him. I am happy because my niece does well at a spelling bee; I would not be happy except that I love her and want her to thrive. We have emotions only if we have concerns.

In this book I refer to any felt bodily states as *affects* (what some call the "low road"), and to concern-based construals as emotions proper (or the "high road").²⁵ Thus moods, reflexes, mimicry, and felt physiological and bodily responses are affects, while fear, suspense, and pity, for example, are emotions. As concern-based construals, emotions are a type of affect that involve a higher degree of cognitive processing than the usual affects and are more clearly identified as intentional mental states. My jealousy has an object, for example, the person who elicits the amorous attentions of my spouse. My jealousy is an intentional state in that it expresses a type of relationship between me and the object of my jealousy. A reflex action, such as the doctor eliciting a "kick" by tapping you on the knee, for example, is caused by something, but its causality is mechanical and hard-wired rather than cognitive and complex. A reflex action may be caused by the appearance of a snake, but it does not take the snake as an object. That is, my flinching is not a mental state that can be said to be intentional. This distinction between affect and emotion is not meant to carry any heavy theoretical weight, and little of what follows depends on any particular distinction between affect and emotion. The distinction is necessary for the purpose of recognizing that while both affects and emotions may be automatic and noncognitive in their genesis, the entities I call emotions typically employ a higher degree of cognitive processing and are intentional states.

Some emotion theorists contend that the evidence supports a claim that some emotion is prior to judgment, and does not result from judgment. R. B. Zajonc discovered what he calls the “mere exposure effect,” by which people come to like or prefer some polygons more than others simply because they’ve seen them a lot.²⁶ Such findings would bolster Alfred Hitchcock’s often-made claim that audiences prefer stars in movie roles because they are familiar with them. If spectators can so easily come to prefer and like certain polygons by mere exposure, then it is no great accomplishment to get them to respond emotionally to James Stewart or Halle Berry. I have already established that in some cases, the appraisals or construals that figure into the emotions are automatic, occurring at the unconscious level. What seems to be at stake here is that in some cases, as with the mere exposure effect, these “judgments” have the primitive simplicity that I have associated with affects such as reflexes. It is for this reason that the distinction between affects and emotions, although it is very useful, must not be taken to be absolutely rigid. Various affective entities bear a relationship to cognition that is as yet unclear.

Emotions occur in relation to stimuli that matter to the organism. They occur very fast, are automatic, and result in ANS responses. Yet if prior cognition is not always necessary to have an emotion, one need not deny its importance in many cases. Moreover, cognition may figure into the experience of an emotion at a “post-causal” stage. Philosopher Jenefer Robinson points out that affective appraisals, which she holds to be initially noncognitive, initiate a response, and for subsequent responses can take complex judgments and thoughts as input. I would only differ with Robinson in her contention that emotions, or what she calls “affective appraisals,” are noncognitive.²⁷

It is probably true that some types of affective responses do not require judgment, if judgment is thought of as conscious deliberation prior to the experience of the emotion. Note, however, that my taking an emotion as a concern-based construal does not require that a construal be this sort of conscious judgment. Our response, having perhaps once been a conscious judgment, might later become habitual, automatic, and nonconscious. But such responses are cognitively penetrable, that is, in principle accessible to consciousness, as, for example, in rational-emotive therapy, in which the therapist initiates new patterns of response in the patient by altering the cognitions associated with various stimuli. Moreover, in defense of a more central place for cognition in emotion, we should also recognize that those who think of emotions as automatic “affect programs” rather than men-

tal states tend to choose their examples carefully and write about simple affects, such as the startle response, that most closely fit their theories. As we move toward more subtle emotions, such as jealousy and shame, or combinations of emotions that stem from the complex processing of ambiguous situations, cognition becomes a much more central element. My distinction between emotions and affects is meant to call attention to differences in processing between simple, automatic responses and those requiring more complex construals.

There is one further reason to emphasize the cognitive components of emotion. It is vitally important to conceive of emotions as mental states. Emotional responses, whether they occur in or out of the movie theater, are not merely physical, but also mental. Bodily states are not “about” anything, but emotions are. Emotions are states of mind that are intentional. Thus, in “The Bear,” Jack’s fear is about something; it is about the bear and the perceived threat to Jack’s safety. My anger with a friend who twice misses a lunch date is not merely a bodily state but an intentional mental state. In addition, my anger can be justified or not. Bodily states such as gastrointestinal disorders or heavy perspiration cannot be justified; one either has this bodily state or not. Anger or jealousy, on the other hand, can be justified or not on the basis of the accuracy and measure of my concern-based construal of a situation.²⁸ Thus, I call my theory a moderate cognitive-perceptual theory because it emphasizes the cognitive elements of emotion while recognizing other influences and determinations as central elements of emotions as well.

BASIC CONCEPTS AND TERMS

Before turning to film-elicited emotion, we should consider some basic emotion- and affect-related concepts that will prove to be important later. For now I will list these and offer a few clarifying remarks:

Emotions are experienced in time. Emotions and affects occur in time and, like a filmic narrative, have a temporal dimension. Emotions are temporal processes, not static entities.²⁹ It follows from this that concern-based construals are also temporal processes. Our appraisal of a situation changes as the situation unfolds. In “The Bear,” we see that Jack is initially alarmed and curious at the sight of the furry animal, then later feels fear after he identifies it as a bear and it spots Jack, then experiences full-blown terror as the bear charges. When the bear leaves off its charge, Jack’s fear subsides.

Emotions evolve in response to feedback. As concern-based construals, emotions are subject to continuous feedback. Our emotional life occurs in streams that continuously evolve in response to ever-changing construals, actions and action tendencies, bodily states, and feelings. Any of these factors can serve as input to affect our subsequent response.

Emotions are related to stories. The type of emotional state that a person experiences is in part determined by the kind of story he or she would most likely tell in explaining it.³⁰ As discussed more extensively below, this is one element of the social construction of emotions. Movies are influential enough that they have the potential to attach emotions and affects to kinds of stories, thus regulating emotional experience.

Emotions vary in intensity and duration. Emotions may be mild and fleeting, or strong and long-lasting. Emotions can build in intensity or gradually attenuate.

Emotions may be mixed or ambiguous. Paradigmatic sorts of emotions (anger, fear, enjoyment, etc.) may occur discretely, but emotions often occur in seemingly contradictory or ambiguous combinations. For example, one can be both horrified and fascinated by a monster in a horror film. While one can easily imagine such a situation, the overall experience is mixed in that the emotions contrast in valence (negative and positive) and associated action tendencies (flight or fear versus attraction and lingering proximity).

Emotions should be distinguished from moods. While emotions typically have reasons, moods have causes. Moods can be brought on by fatigue, the weather, depressive or elative drugs, physiological changes in the body, and the sensory input common to the viewing of movies, such as sounds or music, high and low key lighting, the perceived energy of the on-screen activity, or various elements of the film's sets and decor. Moreover, emotions are often specified by the object to which they are directed, but moods need not have an object. I may be anxious about a public speaking engagement, but I may simply have free-floating anxiety. On the other hand, I cannot be afraid without being afraid of something. That said, moods and emotions are closely related.

Moods influence emotion and vice versa. Moods may affect the priming of a subject to experience a certain emotion, or may affect

the intensity of an emotion. Having a particular emotion can dispose one to being in a particular mood, and being in a certain mood can predispose one to having certain emotions. If I am in a depressed mood, for example, I might well be more likely to construe a situation more negatively than if I am in an elated mood. Conversely, when I experience joy in relation to some particular event, this may well put me into a happy mood.

Priming refers to our situational, short-term propensity to experience a certain emotion or emotions. We are primed (or not) to experience an emotion by diverse factors, including mood, mental set, and immediately prior or simultaneously experienced emotions. In "The Bear," Jack has been primed to experience fear by warnings he has received that dangerous bears are in the area. Jane, who has been told that her pistol will easily protect her from any bear, has been primed in such a way that she will less easily experience fear when confronted with a bear.

Disposition refers to our long-term propensity to experience certain emotions in relation to situations and construals. In "The Bear," Jack has been jumpy his entire life. He tends to think that all wild animals are dangerous; he flinches when he sees a spider and thinks that the squirrels in his backyard have rabies. Thus, he has a disposition to experience fear when he sees a bear. Jane, on the other hand, is a fearless daredevil, courting danger as a kind of fun. Very little scares her, and she is disposed to remain calm in the presence of a bear.

EMOTIONS INSIDE AND OUTSIDE THE MOVIE THEATER

So far I have presented a general theory of the human emotions. Now I turn to emotions as they are elicited in movie viewing. Film viewing and emotions have been paired since the early twentieth century, when Hugo Munsterberg, one of the early theorists of what was then a relatively new art form, wrote that to "picture emotions must be the central aim of the photoplay."³¹ Munsterberg's idea was cutting-edge at that time, having strong affinities with the new expression theories of art being propounded by Benedetto Croce and Robin George Collingwood. Expression theorists typically held that art should be an expression of the mind of the artist and/or expressive of feelings or emotions generally. For Croce and Collingwood, such expression of emotion takes on striking importance because it is seen as distinct from and prior to conceptual knowledge. Art

becomes an essential way of knowing, offering a means unavailable to philosophy, history, and the sciences.³²

Some art theorists have held that the noblest experience of art is experience of the “aesthetic emotions.” Such emotions, as Clive Bell writes, reach “the superb peaks of aesthetic exaltation” and constitute a “sublime state of mind.” “And let no one imagine,” Bell continues, “because he has made merry in the warm tilth and quaint nooks of romance, that he can even guess at the austere and thrilling raptures of those who have climbed the cold, white peaks of art.”³³ Bell fails to adequately describe the source of such aesthetic emotions, appealing finally to a vague concept of “significant form.”³⁴ One doubts, in any case, that Bell would have thought that aesthetic emotions had any place in the viewing of *Bonnie and Clyde* (1967), *Terminator 2: Judgment Day* (1990), or *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* (2005). The emotions of which Bell writes are reserved for elite artists and critics. But even if we grant that such “aesthetic” emotions exist, they are not central to my attempts to shed light on the kind of mass emotions generally elicited by movies.

Rather than posit some entirely different breed of emotion, I argue that “art emotions,” the emotions and affects elicited by narrative film and the other arts, have close affinities with the typical emotions of our extra-filmic lives. Emotions at the movies tend to result from similar kinds of concern-based construals. Moreover, emotions experienced in response to fiction elicit facial expressions very close to those one might have outside the movie theater. In many cases, the physiological effects will also be much the same. In the movies and in life, sadness and sentiment may well lead to tears, joy and happiness to smiles, fear to tenseness and the characteristic pursed lip, and relief to an expulsion of air in the form of a sigh and relaxation.

To find similarities between emotional responses to life and emotional responses to films is not to make the claim that movies are wholly realistic. Of course, movies are hardly transparent recordings of reality, but instead are conventional, expressive, exaggerated, or otherwise manipulated expressions. Yet they nonetheless draw on the structures of response spectators bring from their extra-filmic lives. Even in the apprehension of moving images that depict fantastical and even impossible fictional worlds, the viewer must make use of real-world perceptual skills.³⁵ When movie narratives are hypercoherent, exaggerated, and wildly distorted, the maintenance of viewer interest demands a connection to the real-world schemas for the concern-based construals that constitute emotions. Thus a sentimental or exaggerated romantic comedy, though hardly realistic in many

senses, still plays in part on typical extra-filmic (and also genre-created) schemas about romantic love and happiness.

Some theorists hold that film-elicited emotions are entirely homologous with those we might experience in our outside lives. Ed S. Tan argues that due to the diegetic effect, or what some have called the "suspension of disbelief," responses to the events of the fictional world are "witness emotions" that are "comparable to affect evoked by the sight of nonfictional emotional events in real life." Tan goes further yet, arguing that the "natural audience of the traditional feature film" would have the sensation of "being in the film," entertaining the illusion that "I am present in the scene" and that "the adventures of the protagonists are actually happening to me."³⁶ For Tan, then, the spectator at times has the illusion that he or she is an invisible observer of actual events. According to Tan's theory, a spectator seeing Jack and the bear on the screen might imagine that he or she is witnessing an actual human-bear confrontation, and might presumably feel threatened by the bear.

Richard J. Gerrig and Deborah A. Prentice, similarly, claim that the film viewer is like a side-participant in a conversation, and that what they call "*as if* responses," that is, responses to the fictional events as opposed to responses to the film as an artifact, "approximate the types of responses viewers would have were they really participating in the film's events."³⁷ Thus, in relation to our film of Jack, Jane, and the bear, the viewer might respond with calls such as "Watch out for the bear!" or "Your pistol isn't going to help you, Jane!"³⁸

There are several respects, however, in which the emotions of the spectator are different than those experienced outside the theater. Two elements of the viewing situation are problematic for claims to direct participation of the sort advocated by Tan, Gerrig, and Prentice. First, the film viewer, unlike an actual participant, is obviously unable to influence the fictional events in any way. That is, there is a radical and ineluctable physical separation between the viewer and what he or she sees on the screen. While an actual participant might be inclined to intercede and otherwise physically respond, the film viewer is wholly freed from the responsibilities of—and indeed, is denied the possibility of—physical response. This creates a serious difference between the responses of a witness of or participant in a real event, and those of a spectator of a fiction film.

One might object that it is still plausible to think of spectator responses as witness or "*as if*" emotions, with the proviso that the analogy assume a kind of witness who cannot interfere with or have any effect whatsoever on what she or he sees. This sort of invisible, silent, unnoticed, and power-

less observer, much like a film spectator, would be unable to affect the outcome of the events, and thus would be freed from the responsibility to take action.

This leads me to a second point. The fiction film spectator, unlike a witness or observer of actual events, knows that what she or he sees is fictional. The world of the narrative is neither physically present nor a representation of actual events, and the audience knows it full well. Were spectators to believe, even for brief seconds, that the battles between soldiers and alien insects in *Starship Troopers* (1997) were actually occurring, or even less plausibly, were viewers to have the illusion that they were themselves in the battle, their responses would have an unpleasantly forceful and terrifying quality that comes when we witness or experience actual calamities. It is essential to realize that the spectator has an implicit understanding that fictional movie events are narrated and not actually occurring and that the film is designed for a viewing that presumes a knowledge of the conventional, gamelike nature of the experience. Only those viewers with significant mental illnesses, temporary mental lapses, and/or the rare inability to distinguish between imagination and reality ever mistake what they see for a reality that is tangible and malleable.

The mental set of the spectator incorporates an understanding of the theatrical context and the public, conventional nature of film viewing. Even if viewers thought the events were actually happening not to them but to other people, they might respond by calling the police or trying to distract the bear. Spectators typically do none of these things because their response occurs within the context of a mental set that assumes the viewing of a film that narrates fictional events. I take acknowledgment of the spectator's awareness of the fiction *as fiction* to be central to an understanding of spectator response.³⁹

THE PARADOX OF FICTION

If spectators or readers know that the events and characters of a narrative are fictional, as I have argued, then why do they respond emotionally to them? Is not such a response irrational and absurd? This "paradox of fiction" is especially troubling for cognitive theorists who argue that emotional responses invariably occur in response to beliefs. If viewers of *The Wizard of Oz* (1939) do not believe that Dorothy exists in Kansas or in Oz, why should they have concerns about her? If they do not believe that there is an actual Wicked Witch of the West, why do viewers respond as though this crooked-nosed, green-complexioned character poses a threat

to Dorothy? This, stated in rather loose terms, is the so-called *paradox of fiction*.⁴⁰

In response, first note that according to the cognitive-perceptual theory advocated here, belief is not essential to emotion. As I am thinking of concern-based construals, emotions can result from impressions or ways things appear to the subject; they are sometimes automatic and only partially rooted in judgments, thoughts, and beliefs. In the original formulation of the paradox of fiction, Colin Radford argued that if emotions do depend fundamentally on belief, then perhaps our emotional responses to fiction are irrational and undesirable.⁴¹ To my mind, such a conclusion by a *reductio ad absurdum* throws doubt on the judgment theory of emotion, at least in its more extreme forms. The paradox of fiction is not so much a philosophical problem as it is a psychological one, since emotion, by my lights, is rarely the result of solely conscious deliberation, is sometimes automatic, and may result from some mix of contagion, associative memories, and concern-based construals rather than simply deliberative judgments rooted in belief.

But why, one might ask, are “automatic” and “unconscious” incompatible with belief? If I instinctively avoid a blow by flinching, surely it was because I believed I was about to be hit. Well, not necessarily. I may flinch instinctively even in cases in which I manifestly believe I will *not* be hit, say, for example, when a good friend pretends for the twentieth time that he is going to strike me but stops the blow at the last second. Or when the adder behind the glass at the zoo strikes at the glass. Our affective life, I would argue, is certainly influenced by our beliefs, but it is not wholly determined by them. In many cases, our modular minds generate responses that are in part independent of belief. Spectators may respond with anger or fascination or pity for fictional beings, but spectators also recognize the fictional nature of the story and respond with actual emotions tempered by their knowledge of the story’s status as fiction.

Three prominent responses to the paradox in the philosophical literature are illusion theory, which holds that we *do* believe propositions about fictional characters (and about which I will say no more); pretense theory, which argues that spectators have emotions within the context of a game of make-believe;⁴² and thought theory, which holds that spectators can have actual emotions in response to propositions they do not believe to be true.⁴³ Of these, thought theory currently holds the most favor. Roger Scruton, perhaps via Friedrich Frege, introduced the term “unasserted thought” into aesthetics, arguing that imagination involves thought that is unasserted, hence going beyond what is believed. We can respond emotionally

to unasserted thoughts, such as imagining losing a loved one or imagining winning the lottery. Imagine smashing your thumb with a hammer; the more vivid your imaginative picture, the more likely you are to respond. The fact that we respond to mere thoughts, as Noël Carroll writes, “is a naturally endowed element of our cognitive and emotive structure, one upon which the institution of fiction has been erected.”⁴⁴ We have emotional responses to nighttime dreams, daydreams, imaginings, and ideas.

We also respond to mere perceptual impressions in both the visual and aural registers. Automatic perceptual response is heightened in film, which presents powerful visual and aural impressions. If much of our processing of the visual and aural world is automatic and unconscious, it is not unreasonable to suggest that much of our processing of the images and sounds of the motion pictures must be so as well. To respond with a startle to the image of a striking snake is neither rational nor irrational, strictly speaking, but is rather a built-in feature of our perceptual mechanisms. Our initial, automatic response is in the second instance tempered, evolving according to the cognitive processing that the initial response elicits. Perhaps the label of rational or irrational can be applied to secondary cognitive responses and metaresponses, but it makes little sense to apply it to automatic responses. Moreover, if the thought theory is right, as I believe it is, the so-called paradox of fiction is not so paradoxical after all.

I have no doubt that some philosophers, and especially those who find the thought theory to be problematic, will be wholly unsatisfied with this brief foray into the paradox of fiction. It does strike me that to take the paradox seriously as a significant problem, however, one needs to embrace what I would consider to be a simplified and rationalized picture of human minds and their workings. We respond to fiction with actual emotions because the human mind is modular. Fictions engage the low road and generate affective and emotional responses independent of belief, while at the same time eliciting higher-order cognitive and emotional responses that prevent viewers from responding as though the fictions were actual events. If human responses were solely the result of rationalistic deliberations and separate from automatic and unconscious “built-in” mechanisms, perhaps the paradox of fiction would seem more troublesome.

PLAY AND THE REGULATION OF EMOTION

There is a sense in which all art might be thought of as a kind of play. Wolfgang Iser demonstrates that reading fiction involves games of various sorts, including play with referential worlds of a text, assembled posi-

tions (or points of view) of a text, possible worlds, and reader's expectations.⁴⁵ Given this conception of fiction as playful, it would not merely be experimental narratives such as *Sliding Doors* (1998), *Memento* (2000), or *Adaptation* (2002) that elicit playful behavior in their manipulations of time and of relationships between story world and discourse world. Classical realist films are also playful, since they too depend on conventional understandings of the playfulness of fiction.

In the previous chapter I mentioned Roger Odin's claim that films invite spectators to inhabit a kind of psychic positioning and to take up a social role.⁴⁶ The kind of affective experience spectators have at the movies depends on viewing conventions, and moviegoing is associated in most cultures with leisure and entertainment. A fiction film is thus a form of play, with the spectator as a participant who, very often, plays along.

What does this mean for emotional response? First, the concern-based construals that constitute emotions at the movies are colored by the context of play. The fictional situation represented, in most cases, has no direct, short-term consequence for the spectator. The spectator has no responsibility to act and respond. Whereas extra-filmic emotions involve action tendencies and often the social or moral expectation to act, the spectator is freed from any need or compulsion to take action. Fiction, like play, can sometimes be wholly serious in its intent, yet even morally and politically serious fictions provide the distance that comes with make-believe. This playful context, free of the immediate concerns of the outside world, allows the spectator to undergo emotional experiences and to entertain desires that are experimental, exploratory, varied, and sometimes far outside the range of "normal" experience. From this stems the exhilaration, and also the possible moral threat, of spectatorship.

Spectatorship is playful and also conventional. In other words, play is governed (sometimes ineffectively or imperfectly) by the rules of social convention. In mainstream American viewing, the spectator's experience is regulated by Hollywood, a culture industry with ideological and economic interests that packages emotions for various tastes and purposes, and by the institutions that provide for the exhibition of movies. Thus, the play of emotion is often controlled for pleasantness, intensity, and duration to ensure satisfaction by the film's end. Hollywood also provides intense and conventionally unpleasant emotions for the demographic groups who seek them out. This is especially true of horror films (which offer the extremes of terror, fright, repulsion, and horror) and "gross out" comedies, such as *Jackass: The Movie* (2002) and *Van Wilder* (2002), that blend ironic, "knowing" comedy with the evocation of disgust associated with close

contact with various bodily effluents. Movie emotions are packaged and sold, and a variety of affective experiences are available to the consumer.

Yet even independent films and films produced outside of Hollywood are regulated in various ways, according to the dictates of independent film cultures, conventional mores and customs, and the localized conventions of filmmaking and viewing. Play serves a social function and is bound by social convention.

KINDS OF EMOTIONS

How can we categorize emotions to better understand those that films elicit in viewers? Below is a table listing and describing the seven types of film viewing emotions I introduce in this section and the next. It should be noted that many specific emotions can be examples of more than one type. Also, some emotions will not clearly fit into one category or another, but may straddle the boundaries between them.

Films elicit both emotions of extended duration—what I call *global emotions*—and those that last only for a few brief seconds, which I call *local emotions*. The global emotions, such as suspense, curiosity, fascination, and anticipation, are important in maintaining the spectator's focus and concern throughout the viewing of a film. For Alfred Hitchcock, it was suspense, that "most powerful means of holding onto the viewer's attention," that causes the public to ask itself, "What will happen next?"⁴⁷ Ed Tan finds "interest" to be the most characteristic emotion of spectatorship. For Tan, interest is the glue that holds the spectator's attention, motivating him or her to continue viewing. High emotion points (local emotions), such as marked sadness, exhilaration, or terror, help to sustain interest and are more enjoyable, memorable, and intense than interest. But interest, Tan claims, ideally covers the entire span of the narrative and can serve as a background for shorter emotion episodes of other, more intense types.⁴⁸

Some psychologists, including prominent theorists of emotion Carroll Izard and Nico Frijda, for example, *do* find "interest" to be an important and even basic or universal emotion. Izard holds that interest, or what he terms "interest-excitement," is "the most prevalent motivational condition for the day-to-day functioning of normal human beings,"⁴⁹ and is fundamental to human constructive and creative endeavors. Frijda similarly finds interest to be a fundamental emotion. For Frijda, each emotion has an associated action tendency. In this regard, interest encourages us to attend to something for the purpose of learning about it and also encourages us to orient ourselves to our environment.⁵⁰

TABLE 1. *Types of Spectator Emotions*

<i>Kind of Emotion</i>	<i>Definition</i>	<i>Examples</i>
Global	Long-lasting, spanning significant portions of a film viewing	Anticipation, suspense, curiosity
Local	Brief in duration, often more intense than global emotions	Startle, surprise, disgust, elation, excitement
Direct	Take as their object the narrative content and its unfolding	Curiosity, suspense, anticipation, surprise, startle
Sympathetic/ antipathetic	Take as their object the concerns, goals, and well-being of characters, either for (sympathetic) or against (antipathetic)	Compassion, pity, admiration, happiness (sympathetic); anger, disdain, sociomoral disgust (antipathetic)
Meta-emotions	Take as their object the spectator's own responses or the responses of other spectators	Pride, guilt, shame, curiosity, disdain, surprise
Fiction	Take as their object some element of the film's fictional world	Widely varied
Artifact	Take as their object the film as a constructed artifact	Admiration, fascination, gratitude, amusement, disdain, anger, impatience

Taking interest to be *the* overarching film-elicited emotion, however, is problematic. Many psychologists do not recognize interest as a discrete emotion, while others consider interest to be a cognitive state preparatory to emotion, not an emotion itself.⁵¹ Although in my opinion Tan is right to distinguish between local and global emotions in film viewing, I have reservations about identifying interest as a discrete emotion that is the fundamental global emotional experience of film viewing. Interest, if we assume that it is indeed an emotion, is so broad and far-ranging that it is nearly shapeless. In its milder forms, at least, it seems to be a precondition for any kind of directed, conscious activity.

The emotions are typically defined in part by a particular kind of concern-based construal, a paradigm scenario that becomes associated with that emotion. Fear results when we judge that an object poses a

threat; the object of our anger is an agent who has committed a wrong against us; we feel shame or guilt when we judge that we have failed with respect to some standard or goal. Interest, on the other hand, seems to require only that an object have some more or less intense hold on our attention, of any type whatsoever. The possible objects of my interest in film viewing would include just about anything—a gruesome car accident, a salivating alien, a futuristic cityscape, a hairy spider advancing on Little Miss Muffet, or a vague repugnance upon seeing a star whom I dislike.

My thinking with regard to interest is similar to what I wrote about desire. Instead of positing interest as a univocal, single entity—a kind of emotion—I contend that when we say we are interested in a film, this interest stems not from a single emotion but from a variety of sources, including global, long-lasting emotions (suspense, curiosity, anticipation),⁵² local emotions (fear, surprise, disgust), desires, aversions, pleasures, and what have you. One of the tasks of the filmmaker is to preserve the spectator's interest, but I do not acknowledge interest itself as an overarching, single emotion that governs film viewing.⁵³

Tan's contention that we must distinguish between what I have called global and local emotions seems right, however. This distinction is based primarily on duration and textual function. Local emotions are brief, their function confined to specific segments of the viewing process; in some cases, through repetition and variation they take on an intermittent function of promoting global emotions. When viewing a film such as *Alien* (1979), surprise and shock often accompany the sudden appearance of the threatening alien, but such emotions do not last long. Indeed, their intensity precludes duration, if the filmmakers expect viewers to endure such a film. Global emotions such as suspense, anticipation, and curiosity, on the other hand, are longer in duration and serve to focus spectator attention over time. Suspense and anticipation play a major role in *Alien* when the spectator begins to suspect that the alien's attacks are both imminent and unpredictable. Thus anxious anticipation motivates the spectator, through much of the film, to be on guard and to watch for the alien's next appearance. The global and local emotions also mutually reinforce each other. In the case of *Alien*, the viewer's suspense and anticipation are fed by periodic shocks and surprises, and both long- and short-term emotions work together to create the contours of the particular experience offered by the film.

Therein lies a major difference between Greg M. Smith's "mood-cue" approach to film-elicited emotion and Tan's and my approaches.⁵⁴ Smith

argues that “the primary emotive effect of film is to create mood” (42). Emotions are brief and intense, he writes. They often require an orienting state that “asks us to interpret our surroundings in an emotional fashion” (42). Thus for Smith, mood is the primary global affect of a film, priming the viewer for the emotions that come only in brief interludes.

In response, I would first note that Smith is not clear about just what a mood is in his system. A mood, Smith writes, is an “orienting emotional state” that serves an adaptive function by priming us to attend to particular stimuli, creating expectations and inclining us to experience certain kinds of emotions. Moods, then, are not emotions themselves but “orienting emotion states” and “tendencies toward expressing emotion.” A mood is “a predisposition that makes it more likely that we will experience emotion” (39). The filmmaker elicits a mood, then, to better enable the elicitation of brief “bursts of emotion.” And an emotion episode consists of a mood (emotional orientation) and “external circumstances” (39) or narrative situations.

Smith’s insight is found in noting the importance of such orienting states to the elicitation of emotion in film. Yet to call such orienting states moods is problematic. Smith writes of “cheerful” (38), “suspenseful” (45), “comic” (50), and “fearful” (51) moods. He describes the mood elicited at the beginning of *Stella Dallas* (1937) as “embarrassment for Stella” and “anticipation of impending class-based catastrophe” (89). Yet suspense, fear, humor, embarrassment, and anticipation are most often thought of as emotions rather than moods. And in the case of *Stella Dallas*, the embarrassment and anticipation are clearly the result of the spectator’s appraisal of character and narrative situation, rather than the result of stylistic cues or associations that Smith favors in the mood-cue approach. The orienting states that Smith describes are complex phenomena that might best be described as synesthetic affect (see Chapter 5), consisting of a wide range of mental and physiological phenomena, including both moods and emotions.

Smith claims that all emotions are brief and intense, but this is not the case. Global emotions such as anticipation and suspense can extend through longer periods of the film-viewing process and may rise and fall in intensity over long stretches of a film.⁵⁵ Moreover, as I have just argued, global emotions are essential in priming the viewer’s attention and generating the expectations that Smith wants to reserve for mood. In many cases, the expectations generated by a film narrative are better described as having been elicited by long-term emotion(s) than by mood. In my cognitive-perceptual approach, the mood created by a film is at times a

notable experience in itself, of course, but it can also function to enable and intensify both global and local emotions.

DIRECT, SYMPATHETIC/ANTIPATHETIC, ARTIFACT, AND META-EMOTIONS

By far the most important distinction among types of emotions for my purposes is among the direct, sympathetic/antipathetic, and meta-emotions. First, let us consider the distinction between direct and sympathetic emotions. Aristotle, considering art as the imitation of life, proposed two kinds of emotions in response to literary works. One is the emotions associated with understanding or coming to understand what the story, or "imitation," is of. As he puts it, people "enjoy getting to understand something." The other has to do with ordinary emotions appropriate to the situation that is the object of the mimesis, or imitation.⁵⁶ I call these ordinary emotions *direct emotions*.

Direct emotions stem from the spectator's concerns about and interest in the content of the unfolding story. Responses such as anticipation, suspense, surprise, curiosity, fascination, and excitement are direct emotions. The spectator may, for example, be intensely curious about how the narrative will unfold, surprised at a sudden narrative turn of events, or suspenseful as he or she awaits the outcome of a precarious situation. Direct emotions typically arise as new narrative information is revealed and we come to understand the story.

Sympathetic or *antipathetic emotions* arise from the spectator's assessment of a narrative situation primarily in relation to a character's concerns, goals, and well-being. Such emotions as happiness, sadness, compassion, anger, pity, and fear are characteristically sympathetic emotions, as we are happy or sad *for* a character, or angry or fearful *with, for, or at* them. While through various forms of empathy (discussed more fully below) we can share these emotions in part, our response is always differently inflected, typically more sympathetic than empathetic. That is, I may empathize with a character, but my response is never purely and solely empathetic, for the reason that I perceive the situation from my particular perspective rather than "from the inside." (The essential difference between character and spectator response will be explored more fully in Chapter 5.)

When spectators sympathize with and "feel for" a character, their affective experience must be different from what they imagine the character's experience to be. We often say we "fear for" or have "compassion for" a



4. The spectator's fear in *Jurassic Park* (1993) is for the characters, not for the spectator him- or herself. Thus, the nature of the spectator's fear differs from theirs.

character. The spectator's fear while viewing the climactic showdown in *The Silence of the Lambs* (1991) is not that Buffalo Bill will kill the spectator, but that Buffalo Bill will kill Clarice Starling (Jodie Foster). Thus my fear is for her rather than for myself, making the fearful experience of my viewing both qualitatively and quantitatively different than my fear might be for myself. And compassion is an emotion that also takes the experience of another, not the subject's experience, as its object.⁵⁷ Sympathetic emotions are "feeling for" emotions, while antipathetic emotions, such as anger or contempt directed at an antagonist, are "feeling against" emotions.

Some emotions are neither direct nor sympathetic, taking as their object either the spectator's own responses or the responses of other spectators. I call these *meta-emotions*. The spectator may respond emotionally to his or her own prior responses, thoughts, or desires while viewing a film. Such emotions may range from shame and guilt to pride and a strong sense of self-satisfaction. The viewer may become teary-eyed during a sentimental scene (due to sympathetic pity or compassion), and then become embarrassed at crying (a meta-emotion). Alternatively, viewers might pity a character (a sympathetic emotion), then take pride in being the sort of person who pities others (a meta-emotion). Or a viewer might wish for the death of a certain character, then later become guilty or ashamed for having so wished the death.

We can also distinguish emotions on the basis of whether they take



5. A fascination with the technology used to depict the dinosaurs in *Jurassic Park*, for example, is an artifact emotion.

the fictional world of the narrative or the film as an artifact as their object. The former are *fiction emotions*, while the latter may be called *artifact emotions*.⁵⁸ Both direct and sympathetic emotions are typically fiction emotions. Artifact emotions are all of the emotional responses that can be solicited directly by the artifactual status of film as opposed to the content of the fiction. Artifact emotions may include exhilaration at a particularly brilliant camera movement, disdain for a hackneyed screenplay, anger at the seeming contempt the filmmakers have for the audience, or admiration for the excellence of a film. The increasing tendency in contemporary Hollywood toward allusions to previous films may elicit pleasure and amusement. According to most illusionist models of film spectatorship, the viewer has predominantly fiction emotions while viewing a film. My contention is that artifact emotions are quite common in the viewer's experience. This is hardly surprising given, as I have claimed, viewers' implicit assumption of the fictional nature of what they see.

It is important to note that audiences can have artifact and fiction emotions simultaneously. When the viewer self-consciously admires (or disdains) the famous opening tracking shots of Orson Welles's *Touch of Evil* (1958) or Robert Altman's *The Player* (1992), these are artifact emotions. The content of these shots can simultaneously elicit fiction emotions. Moreover, there is a sense in which the tracking shots, by the way in which they present the fictional world, also elicit fiction emotions. A static long

shot presents fictional worlds and characters differently from a tracking shot; perhaps the former projects stability or solidity, for example, while the latter projects malleability, fluidity, and energy.

MEMORY TRACES AND ASSOCIATIONS

Viewer emotions are typically elicited by external stimuli provided by the film, but responses to such stimuli are often dependent on the memories and associations the viewer brings to the film. In this chapter, I developed a working conception of human emotion that considers emotions as concern-based construals. Construals become emotions in relation to powerful concerns. I use the word “concern” here in a broad sense: a concern is anything that involves us, has a bearing on our interests, or worries us. When viewing *The Silence of the Lambs*, the viewer develops various concerns, ranging from a desire to see and learn more about the evil but fascinating Hannibal Lecter to a sympathetic concern that Clarice Starling escape the clutches of the killer Buffalo Bill and prove herself to be a worthy FBI agent. The stronger the concern, the more intense the viewer’s emotional response will be. The stronger my fascination with Hannibal Lecter, the greater my curiosity about and anticipation of what he will do next. The stronger my concern for Clarice Starling’s well-being, the greater my suspense as she confronts Buffalo Bill in his dark basement.

The intensity of viewer response depends on other factors as well. Other sources of affective power are memory traces, learned associations, and affective contagion. I will discuss affective contagion in some depth in Chapter 4, so here I primarily consider memory traces and learned associations. The emotions viewers have in response to films are partly the product of learning. Various pieces of music, images, sounds, and paradigmatic narrative situations become associated with prior life experiences and take on some of the emotional associations that viewers have had previously.⁵⁹

Mental associations and memory traces may be sparked by the viewing of a film or other artistic work. This suggestiveness of works of art figures centrally in the Sanskrit poetics of Anandavardhana and Abhinavagupta, who discuss *rasa*, the feeling component of experiencing a work of art. For Abhinavagupta (as recounted by Patrick Colm Hogan), memories are both representational and emotional.⁶⁰ That is, we do not merely remember events or persons (as images, in language, etc.); we remember them *emotionally*. Our memories are suffused with the coloring of affect. Abhinavagupta believed, in addition, that there are times when these

emotional memory traces are activated such that the representational content of the memory lies beneath the surface of consciousness, while the affective component emerges and is felt consciously. In other words, we feel something without conscious knowledge of the object of the emotion. Thus, works of art may elicit feelings that stem from emotion-laden memory traces without the representational content of the memory having been made explicit.

For Abhinavagupta, aesthetic pleasure “results from the ‘generalization’ of emotion in *rasa*, which is to say, the removal from the self-interest that is part of the link between the affect and the representational content in memory traces.”⁶¹ *Rasa* is emotion that is in part isolated from self-interest, is empathic in nature, and is for these reasons comparable to religious enlightenment.

My response to such claims is this. It may be that in certain cases, film-elicited emotions are caused by memory traces, learned associations, emotional contagion, and the like. More often, however, such stimuli serve as intensifiers or enablers of emotions, rather than the objects of emotions. To illustrate my point, I will provide a personal example. More than twenty-five years ago, a month after the unhappy end to a romantic relationship, I viewed the Elia Kazan film *Splendor in the Grass* (1961). This drama, set in rural Kansas, is about a teenage couple whose families pressure them to break up, causing the pair excruciating emotional pain. Although their breakup had only superficial similarities to my own experience, this film threw me into a fit of strong emotion that lasted for hours. While I would still say that it was the particular narrative of *Splendor in the Grass* that was the object of my emotion, there is no doubt that my recent experience with a wayward romantic other perhaps enabled, and certainly intensified, my emotional response.

Thus emotions and affects are elicited in films by prefocused narratives designed to foster concern-based construals, but are in part enabled and intensified by associations, habits, dispositions, or conditioned responses that suggest either the reasons for the emotion or the emotion itself.⁶² In film, of course, such suggestiveness may occur in many ways, through whatever objects, persons, events, or environments that can be represented visually or aurally. When one considers the vividness with which films may represent events and other phenomena, it would not be an exaggeration to say that the medium has a particularly strong capacity to elicit affects rooted in memories and associations and to both enable and intensify associated emotional responses. What I claim in the next chapter is that Hollywood presents narrative paradigm

scenarios—basic stories rooted in common human concerns—that are likely to have emotional resonance with a significant cross-section of the potential audience.

SUMMARY: EMOTIONS AT THE MOVIES

In this chapter, I argued that emotions are best conceived of as concern-based construals. Fiction film–elicited emotions are in some ways similar to emotional responses to actual events in that they are also concern-based construals. Film-elicited emotions differ in fundamental respects, however. First, an element of any spectator’s mental set, and thus of her or his construal of narrative events, is a thorough awareness of the fictionality of what is seen together with some knowledge of the conventions of fiction in the film viewing context. Film-elicited emotions occur within conventional contexts of play and its regulation, and within the context of the institutions of fictional movies. The so-called paradox of fiction need not pose an insurmountable problem for moderate cognitive theorists, since emotions do not necessarily depend on belief, and in any case, the argument that we can have responses to “unasserted thoughts,” if correct, dissolves the paradox. Film-elicited emotions come in many varieties, and recognizing various types helps understand their functions. This chapter distinguished between local and global emotions, fiction and artifact emotions, and direct, sympathetic/antipathetic, and meta-emotions.

Many questions remain. If film-elicited emotions are concern-based construals, how does the film’s narration prod or manipulate the viewer’s concerns, and how are construals of situations emotively prefocused? How does style contribute to emotive prefocusing? How does character engagement, or what many call “identification,” figure in this process? In the following chapter, I turn to the specific means by which films elicit emotion in relation to narration, narrative structure, and character engagement.

3. Stories and Sympathies

In order to discuss [films] critically we have to find ways of defining the nature of our involvement.

V. F. PERKINS¹

This book examines the elicitation of affect in mainstream American films, or what might be called Hollywood movies. This begs a question about what constitutes a mainstream movie. The popularity of recent unconventional films such as *Memento* (2000), *Adaptation* (2002), *Thirteen Conversations about One Thing* (2001), *Being John Malkovich* (1999), *Magnolia* (1999), and *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004) makes it necessary to delimit my object of study. These films are marginally mainstream in their widespread distribution and popularity, but to one degree or another, they experiment with form and style to such an extent that they differ significantly from conventional filmmaking. In this book, I concentrate on films that illustrate significant conventional practices for the elicitation of emotion. Just as film production teachers often advise students to learn filmmaking conventions such as the 180-degree rule or three-point lighting in order to better understand alternative techniques, I think it is wise to first examine affect elicitation in mainstream films before turning to more formally daring and creative works.

In this chapter, I describe the ways movies in the “classical Hollywood style” are designed to elicit emotion through narrative structure, character engagement, and the employment of conventional narrative scenarios. This chapter identifies some of the primary structural features of the classical Hollywood cinema, or what I simply refer to as “movies,” as they relate to affect and emotion. The classical Hollywood cinema is a mode of filmmaking designed to elicit strong emotions, and it does so in large part by means of identifiable conventions.

AFFECTIVE PREFOCUSING

Emotions have many roles in human life; one of these is the “searchlight function.”² As we make our way through the world, we are bombarded with diverse stimuli, most of which we ignore and some of which we pay attention to. Emotions direct us to quickly and efficiently sort out what is salient from what is not, helping us organize these sense impressions into gestalts. Thus, we not only pay attention to certain details and ignore others, we also search the environment for specific types of stimuli relevant to our concerns about and appraisals of the environment in which we move. Emotions direct us to salient elements of our environment, bringing relevant perceptual phenomena to our attention.

When we watch a film, our attention is also at play, and we direct it according to our concerns about and construal of the fictional situation unfolding before us. Unlike the outside world, however, many fictions—and certainly mainstream movies—are *affectively prefocused*.³ Built into a movie is a particular way of seeing events and characters, a specific order and duration to those events—in short, a built-in gestalt or perspective. Most mainstream films seem designed to elicit very specific emotional responses, such as fright and suspense in much of *Jurassic Park* (1993), or sentiment, tears, and laughter in romantic comedies such as *Sleepless in Seattle* (1993) or *You’ve Got Mail* (1998). Independent films of a certain sort are more likely to elicit ambiguous or contradictory affects or emotional distance. Jim Jarmusch’s *Stranger Than Paradise* (1984), *Down by Law* (1986), and *Mystery Train* (1989) preclude the strong character allegiances and emotional responses of mainstream film, instead opting for an ironic and distanced response. Yet even this distancing is a type of emotive prefocusing that discourages strong sympathetic responses and encourages ironic amusement and a distanced curiosity.

All films are affectively prefocused to some extent. We might even say that many narrative films are in part embodiments of sequences of concern-based construals in the medium of film. That is, films represent characters and events but also embody or prefigure ways of responding to them. These construals may be unified and cohesive, or they may be ambiguous and even contradictory in valence. In whatever case, it makes sense to think of a narrative film as representing narrative events presented in such a way that they are prefocused to provide a particular complex of affective experiences.⁴ This being so, the spectator’s response to the film depends on a willingness to assent to the prefocused construals it offers.

The spectator may assent to or resist the intended responses embodied in prefocused narrations, and may do so in whole or in part.

PARADIGM SCENARIOS

To get at the relationship between film stories and emotions, consider this observation. Emotions, like film viewings, occur not as static events but as temporal processes. Emotions unfold in time according to the subject's evolving construal of situations. As psychologist James R. Averill writes, "Emotional feelings are not like snapshots that capture only events of the moment. Instead, they resemble motion pictures that depict a story."⁵ The fundamental arena for study of the processes of emotions is the person-environment relationship, as the individual finds him or herself in situations that unfold in time. These person-event relationships might be called adaptational encounters, or episodes. Such adaptational encounters result in concern-based construals that are in transition from moment to moment as the conditions of our lives change. Emotions are a process; they change and flow over time. We experience emotions, then, in relation to the narratives of our lives as responses to unfolding situations and our concern-based construals of those situations.

Emotions and storytelling thus have clear connections. As concern-based construals, emotions can be communicated as stories—stories we tell ourselves about our experiences. Narrative films, simply put, are representations of concern-based construals not about ourselves, but about fictional events and characters. Movies tend to consist of hypercoherent narratives that organize experience to a much greater degree than we would normally face in our lives. Not only are movie narratives prefocused, exaggerated, and dramatic, but their subject matter is drawn from the kinds of scenarios that will be accessible to mass audiences.

As children mature, they are made familiar with the vocabulary of the emotions through "paradigm scenarios," types and sequences of events that are associated with certain emotions. As Ronald de Sousa writes, "our emotions are learned rather like a language and . . . they have an essentially dramatic structure. The names of emotions do not refer to some simple experience; rather, they get their meaning from their relation to a situation type, a kind of original drama that defines the roles, feelings, and reactions characteristic of that emotion."⁶

Small children learn to identify emotions through paradigm scenarios they see acted out in their lives. By the age of two or three, toddlers become aware of other people and of the fact that various par-

ticipants in the same situation will respond differently to that situation depending on their role in it. By the age of three, children begin to understand that certain events are associated with particular emotions, and that their actions may lead to another's distress or delight. Most importantly, infants first learn to talk about emotions via stories, and by the time they are four or five years old, they associate stories with corresponding emotions. Stories, art, and culture continue to teach us about emotions later in life. De Sousa claims that "in literary cultures, [paradigm scenarios] are supplemented and refined by literature."⁷ (It is perhaps a symptom of residual elitism that de Sousa omits mention of the influence of popular narrative in the visual media, which would seemingly play an important role in such processes in the contemporary world.)

We seem to be genetically programmed to respond with specific emotions to certain types of situations. Cross-culturally, a clear and immediate threat to one's survival—the impending crash of an airplane on which one is a passenger, for example—elicits fear. Culture and various forms of socialization influence responses to various paradigm scenarios, however. The same paradigm scenario—the theft of a valued object, for example—may elicit anger in both men and in women, but gender socialization might differ in regard to the expression of anger and its "criteria of appropriateness." Anger tends to be accepted more in men, while some may consider angry women as "bitches," or worse yet, "hysterical" (which denies the legitimacy of their anger altogether). Thus, a man may be socialized to experience an episode of anger as indignation, while a woman may be less inclined to assign blame, and instead feel sadness or frustration.⁸ This is important to note not only for its revelations about this specific case, but also because it points to the flexibility of a cognitive-perceptual model in dealing with spectator differences. In this case, the cognitive-perceptual model of emotion can account for gender differences that might influence both the construal and the concern on which it is based, thus altering the nature of the emotion experienced.

Consider the paradigm scenario for fear. Fear occurs when the subject construes her or his safety or well-being as being significantly threatened, and the object of the fear is the source of the threat. The relationship of emotions to stories is a key to the ideological significance of Hollywood, because the movies show us how and what to fear by constructing and foregrounding objects of fear, formulating the nature of the threat, and demonstrating "proper" responses. Should we fear swimming due to the threat of sharks, or sleeping alone in dark bedrooms that might be haunted

by ghosts? The movies have an influence in altering and exaggerating our fears, in part based on the scenarios for fear that are consistently repeated. We call scenarios that are consistently repeated until they become conventional “paradigm scenarios.” Not all paradigm scenarios as portrayed in film are so simple and distinct as the scenarios for fear in the above examples. Film genres also embody combinations of paradigm scenarios, scenarios that are exaggerated, transformed, combined, and repeated according to various conventions.

Emotions, then, are drawn from scenarios, the very stuff of narrative. Frederick H. Lund writes that “fear, horror, disgust, repulsion, aversion, dislike, annoyance, anger, sadness, sorrow, despair, hopelessness, pity, sympathy . . . are not descriptive of so many internal or organic states. They are descriptive of objective situations and of accepted modes of handling and dealing with these.”⁹ Emotions are ways of interpreting the world, constructing and drawing from narrative paradigm scenarios that frame a situation as one for which a particular sort of response—anger, indignation, compassion, jealousy, for example—is appropriate. The pre-focused narratives of movies, then, are also ways of interpreting the world, not only by what they show, but in their manner of focusing emotional response.

PRIMARY EMOTIONS AND THE MOVIES

What sort of paradigm scenarios does Hollywood draw from? Many scholars emphasize the place of emotions in organizing common behaviors that are necessary to all organisms to survive. These universal behaviors include, for example, protection of the self (fear), destruction of enemies or obstacles (anger), reproduction (love, affection, joy), rejection (disgust), loss and/or reintegration (crying, sadness), and exploration (expectation, surprise).¹⁰ Each of these behaviors is a response to particular kind of adaptive encounter.

Most psychologists make a distinction between those emotions thought to be more or less innate and essential for human adaptation and those culturally conditioned to a greater degree.¹¹ The more culturally variable emotions, such as envy or jealousy, are greatly variable across cultures and not readily seen in other species. On the other hand, the basic emotions—fear, anger, sadness, joy, and love and affection—can be observed cross-culturally and even in other species. Psychologists differ significantly in their estimations about how many emotions are primary or basic and just which emotions those are. Rather than get into these debates,

however, I am content to make use of the basic assumption that some emotions are more universal than others.

Most often, movies are made up, at least in part, of paradigm scenarios that correspond to primary emotions and to common adaptive behaviors. Although movies sometimes intentionally make appeals to segmented audiences, they typically represent scenarios to which people can respond across demographic lines and, increasingly, across cultures. My argument is not that people respond to the same scenarios in the same way; it is merely that the narratives consist of common emotion scenarios. These are often scenarios of coupling/mating, integration into the social group, and/or survival in the face of threat.

In *Beowulf* (2007), for example, the titular hero defends his tribe against the voracious Grendel and later a fire-breathing dragon, couples with two different women in addition to a womanlike entity (the alluring cave monster played by Angelina Jolie), and wrestles with shame for his ill treatment of his queen. The relevant paradigm scenarios here are survival, coupling and/or mating, and an integration into the social group that may involve conflicts between individual and group desires. *Titanic* (1997) embodies similar paradigm scenarios of coupling/mating between Rose (Kate Winslet) and Jack (Leonardo DiCaprio), integration into or departure from the social group (as Rose must decide whether to leave her family and fiancé for Jack, and Jack is invited to dinner among the social elite), and survival in the face of catastrophe (the sinking of the *Titanic*). In *Jaws* (1975), the protagonists battle for survival against a voracious enemy shark, but the story also centrally involves the formation of a social group in the face of grave danger, as the very different personalities of the sheriff, the shark expert, and the grizzled sea captain must mesh in order to form a unified front against their mortal enemy. *Do the Right Thing* (1989) explores the difficulties of integration within the group (family, ethnicity) and between groups (ethnicities). In *Pretty Woman* (1990), Vivian (Julia Roberts) not only finds romantic love (coupling/mating), but must explore, orient herself to, and incorporate herself within her new environment and social group (an elite, wealthy society).

These are all situations that correspond to common paradigm scenarios that are, to some degree at least, cross-culturally understandable and to which diverse individuals can respond. Aggression and survival, coupling and mating, integration into the group—all of these are subject to specific cultural and historical circumstances. Nonetheless, these scenarios retain core elements that are fundamental to human existence. The economic

requirements of Hollywood filmmaking make the appeal to basic scenarios unsurprising.

If paradigm scenarios are understandable to large numbers of people, it is nonetheless true that particular types of scenarios will appeal to some more than others. Thus, Hollywood uses genre classifications to allow audiences to choose kinds of scenarios that promise specific kinds of emotional experiences. Action/adventure films appeal to the supposed masculine concerns of survival, acquisition of goods, heroic fantasy, and power and aggression, eliciting emotions such as suspense, excitement, anger, and vengefulness, but most importantly offering a fast-moving and strongly visceral experience. Romantic comedies replay scenarios of romantic union, and melodramas replay scenarios of social separation, union, and sacrifice among lovers and families generally. Both melodrama and romantic comedy underplay the visceral excitement of action and movement in favor of the sympathetic emotions and affective responses. The Western, of course, is set in a specific geographical and historical context, but nonetheless retains some cross-cultural appeal because its scenarios are more generally tales of masculine negotiation between the demands of wilderness and civilization, as well as a kind of ritual exercise of power (violence) for revenge or self-preservation.

Hollywood stories, then, do not simply report a series of events; movies elicit desires, aversions, concerns, and sometimes judgments, all rooted in variations on the most basic paradigm scenarios. Narrative literature and film are uniquely suited to expressing and embodying emotional experience of the prototypical kind, that is, they embody emotions as the concern-based construals spectators have in relation to the unfolding events of the narrative. This is not *only* a matter of expression, however. To comprehend a narrative, the spectator must not only recognize the expression but also engage with it by, at least to some extent, *having* something like the desires and affective responses initiated by the narration.

Hollywood fictions, so described, are commodified, prefocused construals designed for varied purposes—first and foremost, for pleasures and entertainment. Economically successful mass storytelling depends in part on the ability of the filmmakers to maintain interest; to delight; to arouse curiosity, suspense, and surprise; and to generate occasionally intense emotional responses such as fear, anger, pity, and relief. Narrative form, as Kenneth Burke writes, is “an arousing and fulfillment of desires.”¹² Most typically, Hollywood narrative is an arousing and fulfillment of *mass* desires, rooted in narrative scenarios that are salient to a broad spectrum of persons.

HOLLYWOOD AND THE NEW HOLLYWOOD

Before exploring the formal means by which Hollywood films elicit emotion, it is worth briefly describing the “classical Hollywood cinema,” for this is the model on which our analysis is based. The “primitive” period of cinema began in 1894 with cinema’s origins and lasted until somewhere around 1906 to 1908.¹³ This period, a “cinema of attractions”¹⁴ in the words of Tom Gunning, was heavily influenced by vaudeville, and appealed to audiences primarily through simple comedy and melodrama, trick effects, exotic scenery, and other forms of spectacle. Around 1910, the classical style of narration began to emerge, and it was fully in place by 1917. The classical style embodies various stylistic and narrative conventions described below, in addition to the general aesthetic conventions of unity, transparency, clarity, and a balance of complexity and simplicity.

For many critics, the “new Hollywood” of the past three or four decades has forsaken the evocation of deep emotion characteristic of classical Hollywood for the surface amusements of spectacle. David Denby, film critic for the *New Yorker*, calls this new trend “conglomerate aesthetics”:

In contrast to films made before 1960, which seem to modern audiences to wallow in pathos, modern films provide spectacle and excitement without emotion. Blockbusters like *Kill Bill* and *Pearl Harbor* offer audiences the opportunity to be spooked, titillated, dazed, impressed, and blown away without giving them the chance to share in any of the characters’ feelings.¹⁵

To put this in my terms, Denby is claiming that recent Hollywood films have forsaken both sympathetic emotions and the general complexity and depth of emotional response for the cheap effects of superficial direct emotions—the fascination and cheap thrills of mere spectacle.

Hollywood has changed, and for some scholars, the change has been epochal, allowing for the establishment of a new period or phase in the history of Hollywood film—the New Hollywood. The movie business has seen increased concentration of power, with 1990s Hollywood dominated by five companies that control the industry more completely than did the majors in the studio era.¹⁶ For the first time, in 1990, Hollywood films earned as much box office overseas as they did at home, and by 1994, foreign box office surpassed American box office.¹⁷ Hollywood films play to an international audience and cater to what is increasingly a world market for motion pictures.

Justin Wyatt describes what he says is “perhaps *the* central development” of “post-classical” cinema, what he calls “high concept,” a style

of filmmaking molded by these new economic and institutional forces.¹⁸ This is a style in part determined by the demands of marketing, with an emphasis on easily sold premises or “pre-sold properties” (such as stars, adaptations from well-known novels, sequels, etc.), a visual form presentable in advertising, and marketable soundtracks. Those who make and market motion pictures have learned from advertisers, who understand that amidst the glut of material littering screens both large and small, an ad with “pop”—sexy models, kinetic action, or striking, easily comprehended images of any sort—is more likely to gain attention. Like advertisers, the New Hollywood often embraces such techniques, a tendency that has been exacerbated by computer-generated images and the ease with which filmmakers can now manufacture special effects that seem to have become the dominant focus in many films. The most extreme statement of the “New Hollywood” thesis comes from Christopher Sharrett, who sees a decline in Hollywood narrative as a sign of late capitalist malaise, arguing that “traditional notions of storytelling disappeared in the hyperactive montage of a new cinema that is essentially visual entertainment, the eye candy of image culture where the referent vanishes amid a whirlwind of spectacular editing.”¹⁹

I would argue, on the contrary, that any claim that classical Hollywood narrative structures have disappeared is clearly false. To find that some recent films have become superficial spectacles, as David Denby does, is not to deny a remaining current of films with engaging characters, involved narratives, and strong emotions. To write of the New Hollywood as a clearly defined break with classical Hollywood is misleading. The changes should not be minimized, yet there remain marked stylistic and structural continuities between the films of classical Hollywood and those of New Hollywood.

In a survey of scholarship on “post-classical” Hollywood, Peter Kramer notes that most scholars identify significant departures from classical storytelling in contemporary Hollywood, but also acknowledge “that the majority of American films stay firmly within the classical tradition.”²⁰ Kristin Thompson, for example, contends that modern Hollywood narratives “are put together in much the same way as they were in the studio era,” and that the basic storytelling tenets of the classical cinema are alive and well.²¹ To illustrate, this she analyzes narrative structure in ten mainstream Hollywood films of the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s, including *Tootsie* (1982), *Back to the Future* (1985), *The Silence of the Lambs* (1991), *Amadeus* (1984), and *Alien* (1979). Classical narrative structure is clearly alive, and although we must be sensitive to the idiosyncrasies of individual

films, it nonetheless still makes sense to consider generalizations about “classical Hollywood” and its use of narrative structure for the elicitation of emotion.

NARRATIVE AND CHARACTER

The overarching structure of classical Hollywood narrative is well known, and there is no need to repeat here what has been done well elsewhere.²² A narrative is an emotively prefocused, structured set of evolving events, usually centering on one or more characters. The formalist toolbox of narratology will be immensely useful if the user remembers that the human significance of narrative fiction is not merely to enable comprehension (as some cognitive theories seem to assume), but to provide a rounded experience consisting of pleasures derived from the arousal, delay, and fulfillment of desires, as well as from affect, emotion, and a host of varied cognitive activities.

Let us first consider how the classical narrative elicits direct emotions. Direct emotions, the reader will remember, have as their object the development of the story events and, more broadly, the contours of the fictional world of the film. Direct emotions can be seen, in Aristotle’s words, as responses to the viewer’s getting to understand the content of the narrative as it unfolds. During the viewing process, the spectator continually surveys the film for unexpected changes and novel information. When a film does its work, the spectator responds to this “coming to understand” the story with surprise, curiosity, interest, anticipation, and fascination. Spectator desires come into play here in a wish to understand what has happened, to anticipate what will happen next, and to put new events into context.

The Royal Tenenbaums (2001), for example, presents the spectator with at least nine idiosyncratic characters whose lives all center around the Tenenbaum house, a rambling mansion peopled by a family of eccentrics and filled with strange items such as Dalmatian mice and the odd memorabilia of a quirky and talented family. One of the pleasures of this film is the satisfaction of the spectator’s curiosity about these odd persons as the film gradually reveals details about their lives in an extended exposition that lasts well into the first half of the film.

Although the film is a network narrative following the lives of several characters, it gives the most screen time to Royal Tenenbaum (Gene Hackman), the patriarch who has been absent from the family for about twenty years. Royal is forced by circumstance (lack of money and home) to



6. The emotional appeals of *The Royal Tenenbaums* (2001) in the end depend on the film's ability to elicit sympathy for Royal Tenenbaum (Gene Hackman).

attempt to reintegrate himself into the family. Simultaneously, he learns that Henry Sherman (Danny Glover) has been courting his estranged wife Etheline (Anjelica Huston). Royal notes to a friend that Etheline is still his wife, and that “no damned two-bit chartered accountant is going to change that.” The spectator’s curiosity and anticipation have been stoked; these are direct emotions, depending little, at least initially, on any sympathy or engagement with Royal or his family. The audience wants to know how Gene Hackman’s troublemaking cad is going to accomplish his goals, or fail in the trying.

Next consider sympathetic emotions, which typically occur not in response to such “coming to understand” processes, but rather arise when the spectator assesses the narrative situation in response to a favored character’s predicament and goals. When the viewer develops a concern that the goals of a character be met, this creates a desire for the attainment or maintenance of the character’s desired state or the escape from or avoidance of an aversive state. In the case of sympathetic emotions, spectators typically align themselves with the character’s concerns, and their construal of the situation is guided by this alignment. In this way, the emotive success of *The Royal Tenenbaums* depends on the film’s ability to elicit spectator sympathy for Royal, despite his rather questionable behavior. After Royal fakes an illness to play on the family’s sympathy, he is revealed as a liar by Henry Sherman and leaves the house in disgrace. But

the experience has changed him; he says the six days back with his family have been “the best six days of my life.” Royal begins to act to his family’s benefit, offering his advice, staging an intervention for family friend Eli Cash (Owen Wilson), who is addicted to mescaline, getting to know his grandsons, granting his wife her sought-after divorce, and even saying a few kind words to Henry, her fiancé and his former rival. At this point, Royal’s goals and those of the spectator become aligned. Royal wants to reconcile with his family and to make up for two decades of betrayal and failure as a father and husband. The spectator’s emotional responses to the film, by its end, become wholly tied to an acceptance of the goals of Royal Tenenbaum. It is intended that his concerns become congruent with the audience’s concerns, and the film’s affective trajectory becomes more sympathetically rooted in Royal’s experience and, to a lesser degree, that of the other characters.

Spectator response need not presume a wholesale acceptance of the goals of a character. Some films create an especially interesting friction between the goals of a sympathetic character and those of the viewer. I will explore this more fully in Chapter 5, so a few brief examples will suffice here. In Clint Eastwood’s *Unforgiven* (1992), the viewer is meant to gradually distance him or herself from at least some of protagonist William Munny’s goals and behaviors as he becomes increasingly violent and vengeful.²³ Such a process of misaligned goals is also common in romantic comedies, in which the spectator desires a romantic union of the two protagonists long before either member of the potential couple has such a desire. In *The Shop around the Corner* (1940), for example, two feuding clerks at a small Budapest shop unknowingly fall in love via a lonely hearts club that puts potential lovers in contact with each other through the mail. Since they’ve never met their correspondents in person, they continue to dislike each other in their work relationship. The viewer’s desire that they form a romantic union generates a suspenseful tension between viewer and character goals, a tension that is relieved when the mistaken identities are cleared up and the favored romantic union is achieved. Sympathetic emotions form when the spectator judges a threat to the maintenance of a desired state for a character. Although the viewers may or may not share the goals of a sympathetic character, the viewers want the character to maintain or attain the desired state, or escape or avoid an aversive one.

The strongly emotional nature of Hollywood film does not preclude a third sort of emotion called artifact emotions. Artifact emotions, you will remember, take as their object the film as artifact rather than the content of the fictional world (although it is sometimes difficult to distinguish

between the two). Time and again, contemporary Hollywood filmmakers have demonstrated that films can elicit strong direct and sympathetic emotions while incorporating reflexive markers that draw attention to the film as a film. The classical Hollywood film is moderately self-conscious, drawing explicit and implicit attention to its status as an artifact in various ways. Most obviously, the titles and credits identify the film as a manufactured product that has been given a name by its makers. Credits also identify the creative personnel and their functions on the film. Certain genres, such as comedy, maintain more instances of explicit reflexivity throughout the film. Think of *Wayne's World* (1992), in which Wayne and Garth (Mike Myers and Dana Carvey) directly address the camera at several points in the film. In most cases, however, self-conscious references to the film as artifact become less common after the titles, and spectators are encouraged to immerse themselves in the fictional world presented. Even here, however, I would argue that the spectator is often consistently reminded of the film as a discourse. This occurs during displays of filmmaking virtuosity, for example, a stunning montage sequence or some remarkable special effects. It occurs in cases of intertextual references that reward the spectator savvy enough to pick them up. It occurs due to the star system, in which the spectator never fully loses the sense that he or she is watching Katie Holmes or Tom Cruise, and not simply the characters they play on screen.

Again, *The Royal Tenenbaums* is a case in point. Not only does the narration self-consciously present its story as a book with chapters, but its gently ironic stance consistently draws attention to the film as artifact. Director Wes Anderson displays art and artifice in the quirky characters, occasionally ludicrous dialogue, and idiosyncratic production design. For an example of the latter, consider Eli Cash's house, on the walls of which are prominently displayed two obtrusive and disturbing paintings by Miguel Calderón, in front of which various characters conveniently pose as the camera makes the paintings a focus of attention. (The supplemental materials on the Criterion edition of the DVD include essays and interviews about the paintings.) For another example, after Chas chases Eli Cash and throws him over a brick wall, we see that Eli has landed squarely in a well-groomed Japanese garden. A few moments later, Royal knocks on the front door of an apartment to ask for permission to enter the backyard, and a traditionally dressed Japanese woman answers the door. Both the garden and the woman's exotic sartorial splendor seem incongruous in this urban American environment. One of the film's intended affective responses is laughter, humor, and perhaps admiration, artifact emotions directed at the

imagination shown by the filmmakers. Thus, the film draws attention to its artificiality throughout, all the while attempting to elicit the strongly sympathetic emotions that depend on the spectator granting weight to the fictional characters and world of the film. This consciousness of the film as artifact plays a more central role in spectator response than is sometimes realized.

To sum up, I consider a fictional narration as the expression of an evolving sequence of concern-based construals that simultaneously take as their object the story content of the fictional narrative, the characters in relation to the narrative, and the work as a constructed artifact. Although we must appeal to the formal elements of the film to understand its workings, these formal elements do not constitute the ultimate significance of the film. My final goal is not to analyze form per se, and not to discover the means of comprehension, but rather look at how these elements influence and otherwise relate to the concern-based construals that lead to a wide range of affective phenomena. Ideally, we cannot stop with form, comprehension, and affect either, for these phenomena relate to ideas, to rhetoric, to ethics, and to ideology.

CLASSICAL NARRATIVE STRUCTURE AND EMOTION

The classical Hollywood cinema, in particular, has developed certain conventions of storytelling—many, no doubt, based on older conventions in drama, literature, and oral traditions—which have clear functions in the manipulation of audience emotion. Narrative form is not simply a matter of the organization of cues to facilitate story comprehension; it also encourages a chronological pattern of emotional response. (Of course, comprehension and response must often work in tandem.) Not all movies share the same narrative structure, of course, but within the classical paradigm, certain tendencies, or norms, appear frequently. These are well known, and here I mention the most central to demonstrate how an understanding of the emotions can account for their prevalence as conventional practices.

The exposition of a story consists of background information about setting, events, and character—information the viewer or reader needs to properly understand the story. In the Hollywood cinema, exposition is often concentrated (provided in one section of the narrative) and preliminary (coming before the main narrative action). It is meant to arouse the spectator's curiosity (a direct, global emotion) and typically initiates the process of character engagement by introducing the protagonist and her

or his environment (thus preparing the spectator for the later elicitation of strong sympathetic emotions).

The story of *The Royal Tenenbaums*, for example, is literally introduced as a book with chapters. The film's first image shows a book titled *The Royal Tenenbaums* being checked out of the library. As the book opens, we see shots of the old brick Tenenbaum mansion, and a voice-over narrator (Alec Baldwin) intones: "Royal Tenenbaum bought the house on Archer Avenue in the winter of his thirty-fifth year." The voice-over, accompanied by illustrative, intentionally artificial tableaux, then goes on to describe the Tenenbaum family, the separation of Royal and Etheline Tenenbaum, and the accomplishments and sundry troubles of the three children (Chas, Margot, and Richie). By the end of this exposition, the spectator understands Royal's failures as a father and something of the effects his actions have had on his children. An emotion is a concern-based construal, and a construal quite obviously requires information. The exposition, which may initiate sympathies and antipathies for the characters, should arouse curiosity. It is only after this exposition in *The Royal Tenenbaums* that the viewer is given the intertitle "Chapter One."

The classical narrative usually begins with a stable state of affairs, a period of relative calm during which the exposition occurs. Though the affective processes may be aroused by simple acquaintance with the protagonist, stronger sympathetic emotions are often elicited later in the narrative. We can think of an emotion as a disturbance with both physical and cognitive dimensions; it is a divergence from the normal state of the person that involves changes in the body's physiological equilibrium. This relative lack of emotion characterizing the organism in a "normal" state corresponds to the stable state in the classical Hollywood narrative structure. The exposition is sometimes considered boring. Many spectators' capacity for curiosity is soon met and may be exceeded, requiring stronger emotions to maintain interest. (In some movies, exposition is delayed or distributed to minimize the possibility of audience boredom.)

The catalyst of a narrative consists of a violation of the stable state. A giant shark attacks a swimmer off the coast of New England in *Jaws* (1975). Thornhill is mistaken for a double agent and kidnapped by foreign spies in *North by Northwest* (1959). A tornado strikes Dorothy's Kansas farm and whisks her into the land of Oz in *The Wizard of Oz* (1939). A wife leaves her husband, forcing him to raise their small son on his own in *Kramer vs. Kramer* (1979). Martians invade Earth in *The War of the Worlds* (1953, 2005). A psychologist is shot and badly wounded by a former patient in *The Sixth Sense* (1999). In *The Royal Tenenbaums*, the catalyst is Royal

Tenenbaum's decision to reintegrate himself with his family and estranged wife, initially for purely selfish motives.

The catalyst functions in part to introduce a problem for the protagonist, throwing obstacles in the path of the achievement of her or his desires, and thus, often, is also a threat to the achievement of audience desires. With regard to the sympathetic emotions, the "concern" part of the audience's concern-based construal arises from the gap between the desired goals for the character and the actual, probable, or possible outcomes that conflict with those goals. The violation of the stable state in a narrative, then, corresponds to a physical disruption brought on by an adaptational encounter. The requisite emotional response depends on the spectator's assessment of the situation both in relation to her or his own desires, and in relation to the goals and predicament of the protagonist. The sudden or gradually emerging conflict raises a concern, and the viewer's construal of the unfolding situation leads to emotional experience. In mainstream films, what follows will be a consistent ebb and flow of emotion, rooted in clear and relatively simple paradigm scenarios, and kept simple and on course in what is commonly called a linear narrative.

To see the importance emotion elicitation holds for Hollywood film, one need only look at the elements of classical Hollywood story structure. All such conventions are employed for the manipulation of audience emotion and the construction of a salient affective experience. Small bits of exposition are scattered throughout the narrative. Since an emotion depends on narrative information, each scene must "bridge in," that is, carefully set the place, time, and mood. It must provide a minimum of exposition to enable basic understanding—just enough information to allow for a construal, but not so much as to bore the viewer. In addition, each scene should ideally reveal something additional about the major characters or expose some bit of new information necessary to understanding the narrative. All of this encourages the continuation of the global and direct emotions that keep audiences fascinated, curious, and interested, both anticipating possible future events and estimating the significance of new information.

The conventions of Hollywood screenwriting give evidence of an implicit concern with the proper spacing of powerful sympathetic emotions and for the maintenance of direct emotions throughout the narrative. The overall structure of the narrative is thought to consist of either three or four acts, each act punctuated by a major turning point or reversal that changes the direction of the narrative, or in other words, significantly alters the protagonist's goals.²⁴ The story structure maintains direct emotions with surprises, uncertainties, deadlines, or problems that lead to anticipation,

suspense, and further curiosity about future narrative events. It maintains sympathetic emotions by altering the status of the major characters with respect to their goals and desires, thus creating the possibility for new kinds of emotions and mixtures of emotions.

The most obvious example in *The Royal Tenenbaums* occurs after Royal is kicked out of the house after lying to his family and pretending to be terminally ill. The experience has changed both his motivations and his goals (and thus constitutes a major turning point). He has previously been insincere in his efforts to integrate himself into his family and reconcile with his wife. His insincerity had made it difficult for spectators to respond to him sympathetically, and the emotions and affects elicited in the film up to this point are primarily direct and artifact emotions. One of the major turning points in the film occurs after Royal takes a sincere interest in his family's well-being and begins to act not in his own interest but in the interest of his family. At this point, the nature of spectator emotional response changes, allowing for strong allegiance and sympathetic responses that are gradually increased until they reach their climactic point at the film's end. Thus, major reversals not only alter the course of narrative events but also alter the nature of spectator responses.

While a conventionally structured film consists of three or four acts, it can also be divided into scenes, of which there may be roughly twenty to thirty. A scene is typically defined as a unit of action that occurs in a single location. In a conventional narrative, each scene must include conflict that blocks character goals and suggests possible outcomes that threaten the spectator's desires for the narrative and characters. For example, the spectator desires that Harry (Clint Eastwood) punish and perhaps kill the villainous Scorpio as the wounded Scorpio whimpers on the grass of the football stadium in *Dirty Harry* (1971). Yet Harry is constrained from shooting Scorpio because Harry represents the law, and to do so would break the law. Thus, many spectators experience frustration stemming from the lack of fulfillment of their desire, perhaps subjectively experienced as frustration with the law itself. From this kind of conflict between a desired and actual state (and sometimes from the resolution of the conflict) stems much spectator emotion.

To provide direction for the viewer's concern-based construal, each scene should have a direction, some favored goal for the character or narrated events that suggest to the viewer a favored outcome. The scene's direction specifies the desired goal or state, and conflict makes attainment or maintenance of that goal or state problematic. When the audience strongly

desires an outcome for a character, and when that outcome is uncertain, the audience becomes concerned, and emotion is elicited.

Some screenwriting manuals also contend that each and every scene must have a reversal, although these minor reversals need not be as momentous as the reversals that occur between acts. Such reversals occur in *The Royal Tenenbaums*, for example, when Henry Sherman proposes to Etheline Tenenbaum, when Richie shaves his hair and beard and attempts suicide, when Chas and his sons move back to Archer Avenue, and when Margot leaves her husband, Raleigh St. Clair, and moves into the Archer Avenue house.

We often hear of the cliché of the Hollywood happy ending, but many films offer mixed endings that nonetheless manage to provide a moving emotional experience for audiences. *Witness* (1985) develops two plot lines, as John Book (Harrison Ford) must protect himself and his adopted Amish family against corrupt New York cops and decide what to do about his growing love for Rachel (Kelly McGillis), the Amish widow who nurses him back to health after he is shot. Book succeeds in vanquishing the cops during a shootout in the barn, but decides that it would be wrong for him to stay with the Amish Rachel or ask her to leave with him. Part of the success of this movie is the complex emotions it encourages in its bittersweet resolution. Corruption has been banished and the evil cops disposed of, dissolving fear and suspense into relief and a feeling of well-being. The Amish society, presented as Edenic and uncorrupted, has been preserved. Yet Book and Rachel, who love each other, must part, which may elicit sadness and regret. Although Book loves Rachel, he threatens the Amish society; thus, his departure preserves the integrity of the group, which has been lovingly represented as a homogeneous subculture uncorrupted by the outside world that Book represents. This encourages a return to normalcy and a calming of the emotional disturbances that the film has calculatedly provoked thus far. The conventions of closure and the happy ending aim to provide the audience with an experience ending in consummation, relief, and relative tranquility. Even if it is mixed with some negative emotions, such as regret and sadness, the audience rests easy in the belief that Book has acted admirably, as the traditional hero should.

To leave it at this, however, would be insufficient. A classical narrative must do more than simply ratchet down emotion by resolving all of its problems and answering all questions posed. Certainly, relief plays into a successful resolution, as the audience is released from its cares and is restored to a state of psychological and physiological calm. The most successful films do more than relieve us, however; they also move audiences,

such that viewers are simultaneously relieved and exhilarated. The emotions generated by the film's end may be hybrid and complex—mixtures of admiration (for the insight the film provides or for the behavior of the protagonist), reflexive self-congratulation on the viewer's part (for having had the right sort of response), and joy or happiness that events turned out as the viewer had desired.

The Royal Tenenbaums has this sort of conventional ending, but with an interesting variation. If spectators have the desire that the dysfunctional Tenenbaums be healed and united as a family, then their desires are attained. After Chas's sons are nearly killed by Eli Cash's careening car, Chas responds angrily by chasing Eli Cash through the house, knocking a priest down the stairs, and throwing Eli over a brick wall and into a neighbor's Japanese garden. After considering what he's done, Chas jumps over the wall himself and lies next to Eli, in an apparent act of reconciliation. Chas's sons lose their pet dog in the accident, so Royal purchases a Dalmatian from the firemen responding to the accident and gives it to Chas as a replacement for the dead pet. Upon learning this, Chas shows his first signs of affection for his father, suggesting that their reconciliation has begun.

Like many comedies, *The Royal Tenenbaums* ends with a ritual community celebration signaling successful social integration (one of the most basic narrative paradigm scenarios). But it isn't a recommitment ceremony between Royal and Etheline; rather, it is Etheline's marriage to Henry Sherman. Royal grants Etheline a divorce, thus allowing her to marry a good man who promises to bring some stability to the family. Nonetheless, Royal has been invited to the wedding, has succeeded in integrating himself into the family, and has even begun to heal some of the brokenness that was in part due to his earlier actions as an errant father.

But there is even more going on here. The dramatic trajectory of *The Royal Tenenbaums* is also designed to foster a kind of emotion that we might call, after psychologist Jonathan Haidt, "elevation."²⁵ Of course, it should be noted that although Haidt claims to have identified this previously unnamed emotion, the very idea that psychologists can continue to identify new emotions is a fascinating and somewhat bizarre idea. Yet it is not implausible. It certainly suggests—and rightly so, I think—that our emotional lives are complex and nuanced, and that our language for speaking of the emotions can be elaborated on and improved. In any case, this emotion of elevation quite aptly describes the sort of emotional response generated by many narratives of the melodramatic variety. Elevation, Haidt writes, is the opposite of social disgust, triggered by the witnessing

of acts of human beauty or virtue. In the epilogue of the movie, the spectator learns that Royal Tenenbaum died of a heart attack at age 68. All of the major characters are present at his funeral. As they leave one by one, the camera tracks to a close-up of his grave, with the epitaph Royal thought up himself: "Died tragically rescuing his family from the wreckage of a destroyed sinking battleship." The epitaph conveys a sense of Royal's histrionic personality and thus is partly ironic. It also demonstrates the film's preferred response to Royal as the protagonist, which is quite sincere in intent. Royal did save his family, though he was largely responsible for sinking the family ship in the first place.

Elevation, Haidt suggests, draws its power from a desire for moral betterment. In *The Royal Tenenbaums*, it is Royal who changes the most, beginning as a selfish cad and failed father and ending as a man who hopes the best for his family and expends considerable effort acting on their behalf. If spectators have come to have sympathy for the Tenenbaums, and if they strongly desire the family's reconciliation, then spectator desires are met—a happy ending. Moreover, the spectator witnessing and appreciating Royal Tenenbaum's moral improvement will experience elevation. However quirky or odd the characters are, *The Royal Tenenbaums* nonetheless provides a classic Hollywood resolution designed to both relieve and exhilarate audiences.

CHARACTER ENGAGEMENT

On seeing *Terminator 2: Judgment Day* (1991) at the theater, "cooperative" viewers—that is, viewers who allow the film to do its intended emotional work—develop a particular liking or disliking for various characters. Perhaps the spectator sympathizes with Sarah Connor (Linda Hamilton) and her desire to protect her son from the terminator assassins. Perhaps viewers admire the Terminator (Arnold Schwarzenegger) for his strength and tenaciousness. And the liquid metal T-1000 (Robert Patrick)—well, audiences fear and despise him for his lack of sympathy and the machine-like way in which he relentlessly pursues Sarah's son John. These sympathies and antipathies, as I will show, are an essential component of the film's intended emotional effect, and they encourage the viewer to develop deep concerns that lead to emotional response.

The very possibility of the audience's engagement with fictional characters rests in part on the human tendency to personify and respond to abstract, nonhuman entities, especially in the context of visual representations. Psychologists have demonstrated this in some intriguing experi-

ments involving animated geometric representations. Subjects who are shown a short movie depicting triangles and circles moving around on a surface nearly always interpret these movements as the interactions of intentional agents.²⁶ The subjects attribute intentions to the triangles and circles, seeing their activity as self-directed. Small wonder, then, that audiences respond to animated characters such as Shrek or Snow White as though they were persons.²⁷ Given this human propensity, it is unsurprising that photographic depictions of fictional characters on the screen are taken to be personlike as well.

Not only do audiences see such characters as personlike, with intentions, beliefs, and desires, but they often respond to such characters empathetically, and sometimes strongly so. Eighteenth-century philosopher and economist Adam Smith writes, "However selfish soever man may be supposed, there are evidently some principles in his nature, which interest him in the fortunes of others, and render their happiness necessary to him, though he derives nothing from it except the pleasure of seeing it."²⁸ Smith called this "sympathy" or "fellow-feeling." When we sympathize, we tend to experience an affective state that is congruent with that which we observe in the character. The sympathetic observer feels pity for a homeless beggar, joy for a competition winner, sorrow for the bereaved, and so on. (This is in distinction to a hostile or antipathetic response, which would feel disdain for the beggar, jealousy directed at the competition winner, and smug satisfaction or *Schadenfreude* in the face of another's misfortune.)

Contemporary psychology and philosophy continue to investigate this complex process. It may be termed either sympathy or empathy, depending on one's preferred terminology. The idea of sympathy has its roots in eighteenth-century moral philosophy, while "empathy" derives from German aesthetics and the term *Einfühlung*, or a projecting of oneself into that which one observes.²⁹ Neither sympathy nor empathy are in themselves emotions, but rather a capacity or disposition to respond with concern to another's situation, and often an accompanying tendency to have congruent emotions, that is, emotions that share a similar valence. Depending on the character's situation, sympathy and empathy may arouse emotions as diverse as happiness, fear, anger, compassion, resentment, moral disgust, and so on.

It hardly needs proving that audiences respond with sympathy for fictional characters. Here Alfred Hitchcock's folk psychological observation about sympathy seems right (although he uses the term "empathy"); audiences tend to sympathize most strongly with those who are familiar to

them and whom they like. Hitchcock insisted on the importance of obtaining major stars for his films because the public was familiar with them. When a major character is played by a secondary star, Hitchcock says, "the whole picture suffers, . . . because audiences are far less concerned about the predicament of a character who's played by someone they don't know."³⁰ Sympathy is key to strong audience response, Hitchcock says, because it is a means by which the audience becomes emotionally invested in the narrative situation. And note that Hitchcock uses the word "concerned." If emotions are concern-based construals, as I have argued, then the viewer's concern about what happens in the narrative is elicited in part through sympathy with the characters.

Before getting too deeply into the contours of empathy, sympathy, and antipathy, it might be wise to define these terms. It has become commonplace in aesthetic theory to sharply distinguish between sympathy and empathy.³¹ I would argue, however, that such distinctions are counterproductive, for three reasons. First, they are stipulative rather than descriptive. Second, they fail to correspond to actual usage of the terms. Third, they tend to generate as much confusion as clarity. Empathy is sometimes thought to be the viewer's sharing of the emotions of a character, while sympathy, as Amy Coplan describes it, "involves caring about another individual—feeling *for* another," and "does not as such involve sharing the other's experiences."³² Empathy, for Coplan, requires that the observer share identical or very similar emotions with the observed, while sympathy requires only concern and/or "feeling for," rather than "feeling with," and presumes no shared experience.

As I argue more extensively elsewhere, the distinction between sympathy and empathy is fraught with ambiguities and contradictions.³³ When an observer responds "congruently" to a character, that is, in such a way that demonstrates the observer's fundamental solidarity with a character's interests, it will typically be a response neither solely sympathetic nor empathetic, strictly speaking. Sympathetic/empathetic responses are usually mixtures of both shared feelings and "feelings for," and more often, they elicit congruent emotions that are not identical or even similar to those of the character. How often does one empathize with a character without also sympathizing? Or sympathize without also sharing some element of the character's presumed feelings? When my friend loses her mother to an illness, I share her sadness (to a diminished degree, perhaps), and I also pity her. My response is congruent in that it takes the same evaluative perspective, or valence, on an event, but nonetheless may involve somewhat different emotions than those my friend experiences. My friend

grieves; I may grieve, but to a lesser extent. I feel pity for her, yet in her grief she does not necessarily pity herself. The emotions I experience, then, are affectively congruent but different in both strength and kind.

Just as in the example above, the film viewer will rarely, if ever, share identical and nothing but identical emotions with the emotions the viewer presumes a character has. I may share fear with a character as she faces grave danger, but my fear may be interspersed with pity (which the character does not feel) or suspense (because I know something about the situation that the character does not know). Those who strictly differentiate between sympathy and empathy may claim that this, as in the previous example, is a case in which the observer is both sympathetic and empathetic. If most such responses are mixtures of sympathy and empathy, however, then the usefulness of the distinction is thrown into question. Would it not be better to loosely use either "sympathy" or "empathy" to refer to this complex process, rather than multiply distinctions that play out only in the seminar room?

Another reason to remain skeptical of strict distinctions between sympathy and empathy is that such a distinction is stipulative and conforms neither to common usage nor to any solid consensus in current psychology. The words "sympathy" and "empathy" are often used interchangeably by regular English speakers. This is no wonder, since dictionary definitions often do not correspond to the stipulative definitions described above.³⁴ Moreover, there is very little agreement in the psychological literature about just how to think of empathy and sympathy.³⁵ Some define empathy as little more than cognitive role taking, without the feeling component. Some, such as Adam Smith, define sympathy to include the processes Coplan defines as empathy. Many psychologists have defined empathy as a process that does not require identical or even similar emotions with the object of our empathy, but rather merely congruent emotions (this is the conception of empathy I prefer).

These terminological difficulties and attempts to parlay subtle distinctions can sometimes be very confusing. Psychologist Lauren Wispé, for example, writes that empathy "is more likely to involve the same muscles and reactions as those in the sufferer, while sympathy responses may be similar rather than the same." On the other hand, to know "what it would be like to *be* [another] person" is sympathy, while to know "what something would be like for the other person is empathy."³⁶ But, one wants to object, if empathy involves the very same muscles and reactions as those of the sufferer, why would this not give us a sense of what it would be like to *be* that person? To maintain a strict separation between sympathy

and empathy becomes a very troubling enterprise, and is probably more trouble than it is worth.

In this book I typically use the term “sympathy” rather than “empathy,” and in line with the recent turn in psychology away from fine distinctions, conceive of sympathy as encompassing, depending on specific instance, vicarious emotion, role taking, and the ability to understand the situation of others.³⁷ The condition of sympathy, I argue, is typically marked by what I call *affective congruence*, a state in which the viewer is concerned for the plight of a character and may experience emotions that have similar orientation or valences with characters yet are rarely, if ever, identical. Thus, the viewer may sympathize with Maximus (Russell Crowe) in *Gladiator* (2000) when he finds his family slaughtered or when he is forced to fight for his life against great odds. We may even share some of the ostensible feelings of Maximus; spectators may be sad and moved to tears, for example, when he finds his family dead. Yet the viewer’s external assimilation of his predicament cannot have the same affective charge we assume Maximus feels. After all, not only are these dead the family of Maximus (and not the spectator’s family), but viewers have a background assumption of the fictional, gamelike nature of the viewing experience. In addition, the viewer may feel not only sadness but also pity for Maximus, while it is doubtful that Maximus would feel pity for himself (stalwart warrior that he is). The viewer’s response will be congruent in that it is oriented toward the same general object, the death of Maximus’s family, even though the emotions experienced will differ in degree and in kind.

Much more attention is generally paid to empathy and sympathy than to antipathy, indifference, and mixed feelings, as though viewers were prone to compassion and not to disdain and dislike. (It is unclear to me why antipathy and disdain receive so much less attention than sympathy and compassion, but perhaps it has something to do with a hesitancy to explore the darker side of human nature.) Hollywood assumes that most audiences prefer a strong and clear moral compass that assists them in developing strong desires and concern-based construals. Thus, many mainstream films offer characters who clearly embody good and evil to ensure that audiences will run on the same emotional track. If the spectator has sympathy for Maximus in *Gladiator*, she or he will strongly disdain the mentally warped emperor of Rome, Commodus (Joaquin Phoenix), and perhaps enjoy the emperor’s violent demise at the hands of Maximus. If one of the pleasures of movies is compassion for the good, another is the satisfaction of disdain and hatred for evil.

CHARACTER GOALS AND ENGAGEMENT

The viewer's engagement with characters is complex, consisting of various cognitive activities and affective responses. It may involve sympathy, empathy, antipathy, neutrality, cognitive assessment, emotions, motor mimicry, and/or emotional contagion (discussed in the following chapter). Classical Hollywood cinema typically features one or more goal-oriented protagonists with whom the viewer is meant to have a kind of psychological allegiance. This is a feature designed to enable a clear orientation for the spectator and increase the likelihood that he or she will respond congruently with the film's prefocused concern-based construals. If the viewer grants allegiance to a character, and the character has clear goals, then the viewer is more likely to strongly desire that those goals be met. Strong desire leads to concern, and concern in the face of threats and obstacles elicits emotional response.

The international "art" cinema encourages character engagement of a different sort. Characters in the "art" cinema often lack the clear-cut goals that mark the protagonist in movies of the classical Hollywood paradigm.³⁸ Many times, characters in the "art" cinema undergo an existential crisis that leaves them paralyzed, uncertain, or unable to act. Modernist antiheroes are in conflict with themselves, have incoherent goals, and are often "victims" of this condition. Though these are no doubt also common human conditions (and thus may be "realistic"), such characters don't enjoy the mass popularity of the active, goal-oriented characters usually featured in movies, instead appealing to an audience that finds interest in a film despite (or perhaps, due to) the lack of a strong allegiance with a character.

In Fellini's *8½* (1963), for example, Guido, the protagonist, is hardly sympathetic, although the film allows some affection for him. In fact, many of the narrative pleasures provided by the film seem to stem from a kind of distanced, ironic evaluation of his character on the part of the viewer. Guido juggles the various women in his life, obsesses about his insecurities and lack of creative imagination, and negotiates the demands of his numerous coworkers on the film they are making together. But at the end of *8½*, rather than resolve these intractable difficulties (as a classical Hollywood film might), Guido seems to fantasize that he directs the entire menagerie with whip in hand, taking on the role of the ringmaster to a parade of his closest relatives, friends, and associates, represented as a group of eccentrics in a circus parade.

The Hollywood protagonist is usually more sympathetic, in part

because Hollywood tends to take an optimistic, some might say idealized, view of human nature. Mel Gibson's character in *Braveheart* (1995) is not atypical. He wins the spectator's allegiance not only for his courage and tenacity in the face of the most barbarous enemies, but also because he is good-looking and kindhearted. Thus, spectators tend to align themselves unproblematically with his goals and are not encouraged to maintain any critical distance or to question any of his motives or behavior.

Hollywood in the late 1960s and into the 1970s produced several films that showed art cinema influences in this regard. In *The Graduate* (1967), Benjamin Braddock (Dustin Hoffman) plays the role of the listless, confused art cinema protagonist until he meets and falls in love with Elaine, after which his single-minded goal is to marry her. (Another nod to the art cinema is Elaine and Ben's obvious uncertainty as they ride the bus to their newfound freedom at film's end.) In *Shampoo* (1975) George (Warren Beatty) is a hairdresser who is unable to commit himself to any woman and has affairs with several. In general, he seems to lack a sense of direction, as his acquaintances point out throughout the film, and he often mumbles nonsense as though he isn't clear about what to say or what he believes. He seems to decide that he loves Jackie (Julie Christie) by the story's end, but by then she has chosen someone else.

The most popular term for spectator engagement with a major character is "identification," which sometimes implies that the audience has the illusion of "becoming" the character with whom it identifies, or that the audience thinks the same thoughts and feels the same emotions as the character does. Although viewers may think some of the same thoughts and share some feelings, the possibility of such a "Vulcan mind meld" form of identification is slight. "Identification" is commonly used in film studies by scholars who assume that the meaning of the word is self-evident. Berys Gaut notes that since the word "identification" seems to be firmly ensconced in critical discourse, we should sort out its meaningful uses to avoid talking at cross-purposes.³⁹ It may be better to dispense with this vague and polyvalent term "identification" altogether, as Noël Carroll argues, because it encourages simplistic ideas about the relationship between spectators/readers and characters.⁴⁰

The viewer's "relationship" with a favored character is one of sympathy, together with an assimilation of the character's situation. That is, the spectator's interaction with the character is both internal and external. The internal part consists of the viewer's hypotheses about what the character thinks and feels, together with automatic processes such as mimicry and emotional contagion, which I describe in the follow-

ing chapter. The external part involves an assessment of the character's broader situation, incorporating information at times unavailable to the character, and incorporating the character's assessment of and response to his or her situation. Given this simultaneously internal and external engagement with a character, then, neither the spectator's thoughts nor feelings can possibly be identical with those of the character, since the response necessarily involves that external portion of character engagement. The intended affective trajectory of a narrative, as I discuss more fully in Chapter 5, is guided on a path that sometimes diverges widely from that of any particular character.

Not all theorists of filmic emotion would agree with me on this. Torben Grodal, who has developed a comprehensive theory of emotion elicitation in film in his *Moving Pictures: A New Theory of Genres, Feelings, and Cognition*,⁴¹ makes the viewer's identification and empathy with characters into a centerpiece of his theory. In viewing a film, Grodal argues, the spectator adopts the character goals, mentally simulates the character's situation, and responds to the film based on that simulation.⁴² Grodal's model is a "flow" model in that it compares the temporal experience of the viewer to flowing down a narrative river. It is a compelling metaphor. The protagonist becomes the viewer's mental raft, so to speak. The viewer assesses the protagonist's goals, progress, blockages, and obstacles, just as the passenger might assess the progress of a raft on which he or she rides. The viewer responds accordingly as the viewer and protagonist float down the narrative river together. The viewer projects him- or herself into the protagonist, responding much as the protagonist would.

Grodal's model is close to the "Vulcan mind meld" conception of identification that Carroll rejects. I suspect that the disagreements between Carroll and Grodal on empathy and identification are in part terminological, however. Carroll's critical target is a theory of identification that would hold that viewers and characters *can* and in most cases *do* share identical experiences. Grodal does not hold this view, since when he defends empathy, his argument could be construed as a defense of "feeling for" as much as "feeling with."⁴³ Thus Grodal's conception of empathy is not the implausible entity criticized by Carroll. Moreover, it seems that Grodal's flow model, adjusted somewhat, would function even if the viewer's engagement with favored characters were primarily characterized by external assimilation rather than a strictly internalized projection into the mind of the protagonist.

Yet in the end, Grodal does shackle the viewer's mental life too closely



7. The existence of several sympathetic characters in films such as *Casablanca* (1942) shows that the spectator's allegiances cannot be simply and wholly granted to any particular character, but are shifting and partial.

to that of the protagonist. We must recognize that the viewer has a mental and affective life, as well as a goal orientation, that is often quite different from that of any character. We can clearly see this in ensemble films or network narratives, such as *The Big Chill* (1983), *Steel Magnolias* (1989), *Grand Canyon* (1991), *The Usual Suspects* (1995), *Magnolia* (1999), and *Crash* (2004), which feature several major characters, requiring the viewer to negotiate the goals of and respond in complicated ways to multiple characters in varied situations. In such narratives, it is the viewer's sense of a separate self that enables him or her to evaluate and respond to such an array of characters. Moreover, in films with only one or two major characters, the viewer must often mentally part ways with the protagonist and desire narrative outcomes that differ from the protagonist's goals. This would be true for any cautionary tale in which the viewer is led to believe that the protagonist is making wrong choices. Consider gangster films such as *Goodfellas* (1990) or *The Godfather* (1972), in which the viewer does not see the goals of the protagonists in purely sympathetic terms. Or consider dramas such as *Casablanca*

(1942), in which the goals of sympathetic characters are partly in conflict—for example, the goals of Rick (Humphrey Bogart) remain hidden until the last scene.

It is for this reason that I distinguish between direct emotions (which take the content of the narrative as their object) and sympathetic emotions (which take a character's situation as their object), and insist that character engagement is essentially both external and internal. Although sharing character goals and emotions is an element of character engagement, the viewer must also negotiate the contours of the narrative independently of the character and view events in part from the outside. This is why the term "identification" has traditionally been so misleading. It implies the sharing of character goals and emotions and implicitly diminishes the importance of the spectator's independent engagement with the narrative.

THE STRUCTURE OF ENGAGEMENT

Murray Smith's formulation of what he calls the "structure of sympathy" has been very useful in explaining the centrality of character engagement to spectator emotional response. In Smith's model, the structure of sympathy consists of the viewer's recognition of the emotional experience of characters, a structure of alignment (explained below), and allegiance, or in other words, the viewer's moral and/or ideological approval or disapproval of characters.⁴⁴ The structures that Smith illustrates operate in cases of antipathy and indifference as well as sympathy; in addition, Smith's concept of allegiance seems quite close to sympathy. Thus, to avoid confusion, I will slightly alter Smith's terminology and refer to the structure of "engagement" rather than "sympathy." For our purposes, the last two elements of the structure of engagement, alignment and allegiance, are most important.

One of Smith's central contributions to our understanding of character engagement is his distinction between "alignment" and "allegiance." The spectator is aligned with characters in two fundamental ways: through *spatio-temporal attachment* and *subjective access*. By attachment, Smith means the way a narration may follow one or more characters though the course of the narrative. Attachment may be more or less exclusive, focusing on one protagonist; may shift between one character and another, or may disperse itself among many characters.

Subjective access refers to the degree to which viewers are given access to the subjective states of the characters. As Smith writes, attachment

shows us what characters do, while subjective access reveals what characters desire, believe, think, and feel.⁴⁵ No particular degree of subjective access is necessarily entailed by attachment to a character, although attachment and access often correspond. Occasionally, the narration may grant spatio-temporal attachment and withhold subjective access (and perhaps even provide misleading cues about character subjectivity). In either case, alignment is a formal process that implies no particular evaluation of or emotional response to the character.

Smith does claim that alignment with a character, all things being equal, tends to increase spectator sympathy, but does not invariably do so. What Wayne Booth calls "the sustained inside view," or what we might call sustained attachment, may lead to a kind of "insider's sympathy" with the character and her or his allies and antipathy toward other characters portrayed as "out" group members.⁴⁶ Booth claims that such a process is at work independently from the reader's moral judgment of the character, or what Smith calls allegiance.

Allegiance with characters is another essential component of the structure of engagement. Allegiance has a stronger moral and affective component than alignment, and is less a structure of the text than a response of spectators to characters. Allegiance results from the spectator's moral evaluation of characters. These evaluations lead to the ordering or ranking of characters according to preference. For Smith, allegiance fundamentally depends on the spectator's moral approval of them, not necessarily in absolute terms, but sometimes merely in relation to our moral evaluation of the film's other characters. That is, spectators sometimes grant allegiance not to the character who is deemed morally spotless, but to the one who is the least morally objectionable.⁴⁷

Two clarifications are in order at this point. First, allegiance and sympathy are related but not identical. It might be good to think of allegiance as a cognitive state that primes one to experience sympathy but does not necessarily lead to sympathy. Thus, one could have allegiance for a character yet fail to sympathize with the character in some circumstances, such as when the male lead in a traditional romantic comedy temporarily pursues the "wrong woman." Although spectators may lack sympathy with the protagonist in such a case, there remains an overarching allegiance with the character. Second, it would be wise to consider additional terminology. We might call lack of allegiance "indifference," and the opposite of allegiance "opposition," or an oppositional stance.

One caveat, however. I would maintain that the audience may give its allegiance to a character (thus harmonizing its goals and desires with the

character) or maintain an oppositional stance for reasons other than moral approval or disapproval, in some cases lending allegiance, for example, because the actor is attractive, or the character small (we find children or small animated characters to be inherently sympathetic). Some spectators have a tendency to root for the underdog, for those who are familiar to them (as in the case of stars, or in the experiments detailed above, animated triangles), or for those who appear to be similar ("She's left-handed like I am!"), who share an affiliation (race, class, ethnicity, gender), or who have other complementarities of outlook that cannot be classified as moral per se. Moral approval or disapproval may lead to allegiance or an oppositional stance, but so may other characteristics.

Some might want to argue that the star system has as much to do with allegiance as moral evaluation does, and that audiences will lend allegiance to characters played by familiar and well-liked stars independent of any moral approval of the characters they play. This may be true to some extent, but to say that stars win audience allegiance completely independently of moral approval is clearly wrong. If audiences automatically granted all characters played by movie stars their allegiance, it would not allow liked stars to play the role of antagonist in a film. Consider Jack Nicholson's several roles as antagonist or otherwise unpleasant character, from *The Shining* (1980) to *The Witches of Eastwick* (1987) to *Batman* (1989) to *The Departed* (2006). Nicholson's star power fascinates spectators, but does not necessarily lead to allegiance with the characters he plays. One could make a similar case about Meryl Streep in *Adaptation* (2002) and *The Devil Wears Prada* (2006). Stars fascinate audiences, but spectators hardly lend their allegiance to stars automatically. In the cases above, moral evaluation, not merely star power, plays a role in developing degrees of spectator allegiance with characters.

Central to Smith's argument—and its significant insight—is his claim that alignment and allegiance are not necessarily coextensive. While a film may align viewers with one or more characters, allegiances may be conflicted or may lie elsewhere altogether. Similarly, a film may encourage allegiance with a single character but disperse alignment among many characters. Or a film may disperse both allegiance and alignment, as we see in various "ensemble" films or "network narratives,"⁴⁸ such as *Grand Canyon*, *The Big Chill*, *Thirteen Conversations about One Thing*, *Magnolia*, or *Crash*. Smith's notion of the structure of engagement, then, breaks down sympathetic engagement into smaller components, provides a useful means of thinking of its component parts, and offers a way to explain its sometimes contradictory and ambiguous nature.

CHARACTER ENGAGEMENT AND SPECTATOR DIFFERENCE

The problem of spectator difference is most striking in light of the structure of engagement, especially with regard to one component of that structure, allegiance. To what extent does spectator allegiance vary with spectator difference? It may help to briefly consider this question in light of gender differences. Of the many ways we can differentiate between spectators, gender differences are currently of great interest to film scholars. Early psychoanalytic film theory proceeded as though the formal characteristics of the film wholly determined spectator response. Laura Mulvey chiseled a crack in the "apparatus theory" monolith when she suggested that pleasure should be differentiated according to gender.⁴⁹ She preserved a fundamental tenet of apparatus theory, however, when she found cinematic pleasure in a unitary source, namely voyeurism and the symbolic dissolution of the threat of castration. For the early Mulvey, then, film pleasures were male pleasures.

Although I am skeptical of the psychoanalytic underpinnings of Mulvey's theory, to say that classical Hollywood film has often assumed a male viewer, at least in some regards, seems right to me. Take Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954) as an example. Much of the film seems designed to appeal most fully to a male heterosexual viewer. The protagonist, Jeffries (James Stewart), is male, of course, and for those who respond to the film, *Rear Window* offers male pleasures. The viewer is perceptually aligned with Jefferies when he "peeps" at the dancer, "Miss Torso," in her apartment or at the sunbathers on the building's roof. Although the film implicitly finds Jefferies to be morally at fault for his voyeurism, it simultaneously and somewhat contradictorily offers the pleasures of voyeurism in its somewhat provocative (at least for the 1950s) display of the beautiful dancer. Jefferies's little smile as he notices the helicopter descending to provide its occupants a better view of the two women sunbathing provides a kind of wink and a nudge at male sexual looking. *Rear Window* also plays to male desires in the way that the spectator is aligned with Jefferies (in both spatio-temporal attachment and subjective access), especially as the female characters dote on him. Stella, the insurance company masseuse, gives him massages. Lisa (Grace Kelly) participates in Jeff's journey of discovery in part because she wants to prove her worth to him. Throughout the film, Lisa caters to Jeff, offering to buy him a new silver cigarette case, modeling lingerie and an \$1,100 dress for him, offering herself sexually, having dinner, wine, and champagne delivered to his apartment, and planting favorable "items" about him in newspaper columns. The film can

clearly be seen as a male fantasy, in the nontechnical sense of “fantasy” discussed in Chapter 1.

To say that even such an obvious example as *Rear Window* offers *exclusively* male pleasures, however, would be wrong. Certainly, the pleasures it allows spectators fall in part along gender lines—but only in part. It is true that in many cases, spectators will find it easier to have allegiance for a character with whom they perceive shared similarities, such as gender, ethnicity, race, age, and class. Yet such affinities are hardly airtight. As many film theorists have since noted, women do sympathize with or have allegiance to male characters and men with female characters. The female spectator may also align herself with Jefferies’s goals without granting him wholesale allegiance. Even were spectators to find Jefferies to be an arrogant cad, they could still align themselves with his desire to uncover the Thorwald mystery, and his desire that Lisa escape Thorwald’s dangerous grasp when she sneaks into his apartment and is discovered.

Moreover, I would speculate that many spectators, both male and female, find Lisa to be more sympathetic than the somewhat cynical and demanding Jefferies, and it is certainly possible that the spectator’s fundamental *allegiance* lies with her, though the film *aligns* spectators with Jefferies perceptually and in the subjective access to Jefferies’s thoughts and reactions. It is Jefferies who initiates the voyeurism here, a voyeurism that the film itself questions, and it is Jefferies who dubiously resists the love Lisa offers because she is “too perfect.” Lisa holds spectators’ allegiance as much as Jefferies, though spectators are structurally aligned with him.

Moreover, many of the pleasures of the film have to do with the unfolding of the narrative and with the direct emotions of suspense, curiosity, and surprise, which do not depend wholly on allegiance to characters, and which are typically cross-gender pleasures. Women, like men, will be affected by the film’s suspense and mystery. *Rear Window*, like many Hollywood films, is oriented toward a male viewer, but offers viewing pleasures that cross genders. Some might also argue that certain elements of Lisa’s character are clearly designed to appeal more to women than to men, so that although Jefferies “controls” the narrative, viewing pleasures are also afforded to women through Lisa’s interests and demeanor. Indeed, it could be argued that at the film’s end, Lisa has taken control.⁵⁰

Although Mulvey is right to claim that Hollywood has often presumed a male spectator, she is able to argue that mainstream films offer exclusively male pleasures only because her account of pleasure is too narrow and too firmly divided along gender lines. As Jane Gaines asks, “Is the spectator restricted to viewing the female body on the screen from the male point of

view?"⁵¹ If I am right that the pleasures films offer are more complex (as I argued in Chapter 1), then we must revise conventional accounts that posit a binary opposition between male and female spectatorship and admit that male viewers may have allegiance to female characters and vice versa. This is not a new suggestion, and is in fact gaining widespread acceptance.⁵² To some extent, the pleasures of the movies, though differently inflected, are cross-gendered pleasures. To be sure, differences exist, for example, in the capacity of spectators to experience empathy and some of the specific emotions.⁵³ Yet many spectator allegiances, pleasures, and other responses cannot be drawn strictly along gender lines.

WHAT CHARACTER ENGAGEMENT IS: A SUMMARY

Character engagement is the trajectory of mental activities and responses viewers have in relation to film characters. Viewers sympathize with, have antipathy for, are conflicted about, and are indifferent to various characters. Engagement involves cognitive assessment, viewer desires for various outcomes, and sympathetic and antipathetic emotions in response to a character's situations. Most classical Hollywood films encourage strong sympathy for one or more characters. This sympathy is pleasurable in itself, but it also ensures strong emotional responses, since when the audience cares deeply about a character, it also has deeper concerns about the unfolding narrative. And deeper concerns often lead to stronger emotions.